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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Women preparing compost manure in Mudkhu Banjyang, Tarakeshwar Municipality, Kathmandu.

Govt's pro-people move has built trust in public, says PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31



Prime Minister Prachanda

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the people-oriented steps taken by the government have increased people's hope and trust in the federal democratic republic system.

Speaking at a special function to mark the 38th anniversary of Nepal Television (NTV) in Singha Durbar on Wednesday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the development of positive thinking and the communication of new hope among the people that 'something will happen now' should be considered as positive achievement.

Stating that the current government under his leadership, which was formed in challenging circumstances, has completed a period of one year and one-month, Prime Minister Prachanda claimed that in the meantime, the government had carried out many adventurous and pro-people works that will be remembered in future.

"Incidents such as the government's investigation into the fake Bhutanese refugee scandal, fearless prosecution of the Lalita Niwas case, and the impartial investigation into the gold smuggling scandal have exposed the crimes committed through the abuse of state power," Prime Minister Prachanda said.

"Laws made in favour of the victims of usury, issuance of citizenship Act for the children of Nepali citizens without citizenship, contribution-based social security scheme, passports, driving licenses for those working in the informal and self-employed sectors have given hope to the people," said PM Prachanda.

Making it clear that the country's economy has returned to normal due to the reforms taken by the government, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "The initiative taken in the field of social justice, including the provision of free beds in hospitals, and the supply of textbooks in schools and fertilisers to farmers, is being praised everywhere."

The Prime Minister said that the current government is committed to building the necessary structures and infrastructure to fully 'guarantee' freedom of thought and expression, right to information and freedom of the press.

He expressed his commitment that providing the right to information will be established as the responsibility of the state with effective implementation of the laws created for working journalists.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that he is aware of the problems faced by Nepal's media as the advertising market of Nepal has shrunk for a few years due to the economic recession in the world and the COVID-19 pandemic.

Prime Minister Prachanda emphasised that the national broadcasting organisation like Nepal Television should take pride in being the mother of broadcasters even in difficult situations.

The government has been requesting that the media operated by using the latest technology should adopt a system of self-regulation to become reliable, responsible and accountable.

He said that with the participation of the concerned parties, the work is being done to draft the media related curriculum and publish it on the website and take suggestions.

"Some of the new policy arrangements made by the government that encourage the development of the journalism sector and the use of technology are not for control, but for the regulation and management," said PM Prachanda.

As social networking media are expanding every day, the responsibility of mainstream media and media workers is increasing accordingly, he said.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the journalists and the journalism profession should be serious and sensitive in fulfilling their professional responsibility of disseminating accurate, balanced and truthful information.

Meanwhile, RSS adds: Minister for Communications and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the incumbent government was committed to making the journalism sector more advanced, professional and prosperous by protecting press freedom.

Addressing the 39th anniversary function of NTV, Minister Sharma said that Nepal Television and Radio Nepal would be merged and developed as more independent, autonomous and people-oriented public service broadcasters.

"Earlier, the government-owned media were understood as the mouthpiece of the government. But now, we are trying to change such type of working style," she said.

Minister Sharma explained that the government-owned media were bridging the people and the government by conveying news and information about the State and its activities to the people, and the people's message and expectations to the State.

"A committee on suggestion for reform of mass media sector has been formed keeping in mind the restructuring of the mass media sector, and the Nepal Media Council Bill and the Mass Communications Bill have been prepared based on the committee's report," she said, adding that emphasis has been given to the formulation of the policies and laws related to the mass communication sector aiming to making the province and the local levels stronger as per the situation developed through the federal structure and practices as well as in line with the Mass Communication Policy-2073 BS.

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NO CHANGE IN COUNCIL OF MINISTERS SOON: MINISTER GURUNG

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Butwal, Jan. 31

Minister for Law, Justice, and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung has stated that there will be no immediate change in the Council of Ministers.

Speaking at a press conference organised by the Nepal Press Union Rupandehi in Butwal on Wednesday morning, Minister Gurung said that Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has the authority to shuffle the Council of Ministers.

Although the possibility of ministerial reshuffling had been raised, that chance has now passed, he added. Minister Gurung said, "This is a coalition government, and any reshuffling of the Cabinet requires unanimous agreement from all coalition parties."

He further said that the coalition parties have reached a consensus to maintain the current Cabinet configuration without any changes.

He said that the bill on transitional justice will be presented in the upcoming parliament session and efforts are being made to reach a consensus among the leaders of the top political parties.

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Nepal Army proposes to revive Hetauda Textile at Rs. 1.93 bn

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 31



The Nepal Army (NA) has said that the Hetauda Textile Factory (HTF) could be revived with a cost of Rs. 1.93 billion, and 2.6 million metres of textile could be produced within the next three years.

In a meeting with Prime Minister, Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' at the latter's office in Singha Durbar on Wednesday, the NA briefed PM Prachanda about the findings of the feasibility study conducted by it and said that the reoperation of the industry established in 1975 with Chinese technical assistance was possible.

It also said that the annual operation cost of the mill would be Rs. 780 million and it will reach at the break-even point nine years from the commencement of operation.

The government has pushed forward the agenda of reviving the HTF which has been in the discussion for the last one decade or so. The NA has conducted the feasibility study for the reoperation of the factory as per the provisions announced in the Policy and Programmes of the government for the current Fiscal Year 2023/24.

The industry had a capacity to produce approximately 36,000 metres of cloth per day. It ceased production of textiles in 2,000 after running at a loss for many years. King Gyanendra's government had decided to permanently shut the mill in 2003 and it has already been liquidated and merged into the Industry District Management Limited.

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Defense Purna Bahadur Khadka, DPM and Home Minister, Narayan Kaji Shrestha, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, Industry Minister, Ramesh Rijal, Vice-Chairman of the National Planning Commission, Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha, Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, Army Chief Prabhu Ram Sharma and high government and army officials were present at the meeting.

Poor marketing, overstaffing ruined the mill

According to the PMO, the study report of the NA has concluded that the factory was shut down due to its inability in market management, lack of technological modernisation, economic burden created by overstaffing and lack of managerial capacity to run an industry of that scale.

It said that the factory could be brought back into operation with the maintenance of some structures and machines, and the budget of the Nepal Army's military welfare fund was sufficient to manage such work. Likewise, most of the raw materials needed for this industry are available within Nepal and the market could be assured as there is a high demand of clothes for the army, security agencies and government employees.

The report has fixed the needs and rationales of the reoperation of the factory. According to it, the revival will reinstall the industrial prestige of the past, contribute to the industrial sector

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Gandaki gears up to draw second five-year plan

BY PHADINDRA ADHIKARI
Lekhnath, Jan. 31

In the final year of the Gandaki Province's first five-year plan, the province has reviewed old plans and formulated new ones. It has prepared a concept paper for the second five-year plan and conducted district-level discussions.

However, the implementation of the first five-year plan appears to be very weak. Out of the 16 indicators of prosperity and 12 indicators of happiness set in the plan, only one indicator of happiness has been achieved while progress has been made in only 10 indicators of prosperity. Among the 23 pride projects, three have been implemented, five have been started and remaining 15 have not even commenced.

Gandaki Province Chief Minister Surendra Raj Pandey said that the infrastructural development was not sufficient in itself, instead ways to develop employment and economy should be identified. He said, "Villages will lose existence without economic activities, so as the cities. Instead of pointing out problems, give solutions."

He said that due to the lack of proper coordination with the local government and federal government's unwillingness to provide constitutional rights, the province faced challenges in collecting taxes and implementing plans.

A leader from the main opposition party in Gandaki, Khagaraj Adhikari, said that coordination with the local bodies and put pressure in the federal government should go hand in hand for resources. Similarly, stakeholders recommend investing in potential sectors such as tourism, agriculture and energy to boost employment and economic activities.

Meanwhile, preparations for the second plan are under way with expectations to submit the preliminary suggestions by mid-February and prepare the final draft including the directives of the Chief Minister and ministers and

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Four artefacts stolen from Nepal returned

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

Four stolen antiques from Nepal arrived in Kathmandu from various museums in New York, America, on Wednesday.

Dallas Museum of Art, Rubin Museum of Art and Brooklyn Museum of New York returned four artworks to Nepal.

Organising a press meeting on Wednesday at the Department of Archeology, President of US-based Newa Guthi Bijay Man Singh handed over the artworks to the DoA.

A pair of gilt bronze Bhairava Mask, Uma Maheswors and a ten-armed Durga statue were handed over on the occasion.

A pair of gilt bronze Bhairava masks, dating to the 16th century were stolen from Nakchhen Pradhan family of Bhimeshowr Municipality Ward No. 2, Dolakha district on March 7, 1994, and reached Dallas Museum of Art and Rubin Museum of Art, USA through several channels.



These masks depict the god Shiva, one of the Hindu trinity which also includes Brahma and Vishnu. They were required for ritual worship during the annual Indra Jatra festival in Nepal.

They were then smuggled to Hong Kong, sold at auction in New York, and subsequently entered the collections of the Rubin Museum of Art and the Dallas Museum of Art.

The stone sculpture of Uma Maheshwora (16th century) was stolen from Chyasal Hiti Falcha of Om Bahal in Patan, Lalitpur, in between 1980 to 1990. The sculpture was located at Brooklyn Museum, New York, USA.

The 10-armed Maha Laxmi/Durga, an artwork created in the 17th or 18th century was stolen from Hanumanghat in Bhaktapur and was located in Subash Kapoor's collection.

The stone statue was allegedly smuggled out of Nepal by the Zeeshan and Zahid Butt trafficking network, which was run by Kapoor's alleged co-conspirators. The statue was then purchased from the Butts in Bangkok by Kapoor and subsequently trafficked into New York in the early 2000s before it was recovered from a Kapoor-owned storage unit.

Receiving the art objects, Saubhagya Pradhanang, Director General of the Department of Archeology, said, "The returned relics are our god and goddess, not merely sculptures."

She expressed deep gratitude to all the museums, the members of the America-based Newa: Guthi, the DoA officials, art lovers and media for their initiative and cooperation in returning the artifacts to Nepal.

She further said that 149 cultural properties including these four, which were lost in the past, were returned to Nepal and many other artifacts are still in several museums of America, United Kingdom, France and other countries.

The USA-based Newa: Guthi has provided financial support to return the four antiques to Nepal.

Concerted efforts needed to retain youths at home: PM Prachanda

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has underscored the need of concerted efforts to retain students within the country, discouraging the trend of migration for education and employment.

Speaking at the twelfth General Assembly of the University of Agriculture and Forestry, the Prime Minister highlighted the imperative to implement programmes aimed at promoting employment and retaining students. Expressing satisfaction over the rise in enrolment in agricultural science, he stressed the pivotal role that universities should play in the advancement of agriculture and forestry.

"The attraction of the young generation towards the agricultural sector remains stagnant. Regardless of the measures taken, we must orient them towards agriculture and increase productivity," said PM Prachanda.

He stressed that achieving the production and productivity targets hinge on the collaboration of professors, agricultural scientists, students, and technicians.

PM Prachanda acknowledged the challenges facing the country's agricultural education, research system, and agriculture and forestry universities. "This university can significantly contribute to the development of agriculture and forestry in the country," he said.



PHOTO: TRN
Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressing the 12th General Assembly of the University of Agriculture and Forestry on Wednesday.

He expressed a vision for the university to play a crucial role in technology production by bolstering education, research, and extension systems.

Commending the establishment of eight faculties of agriculture and one college under the faculty of forestry, along with two agricultural science centres in different provinces, aligning to establish formal colleges in all provinces, the Prime Minister proposed initiating educational programmes in the approved colleges of Syangja and Gorkha.

PM Prachanda stressed the vital role universities should play in boosting production and productivity, achieving import substitution in agriculture, promoting exports, and reducing the national trade deficit.

He urged the university to make policy recommendations based on necessary research to enhance the economic status and employment of communities, emphasizing the scientific management of forests for timber and non-timber forest products.

To amplify the contribution of agriculture, livestock, and forest sectors to economic development, Prime Minister Prachanda suggested that the university collaborate with national and international stakeholders in teaching, research, and dissemination activities to elevate the economic status of rural communities.

Directing attention to challenges such as global climate change, food insecurity, and unemployment, the Prime Minister called for strategies to increase farmers' income and ensure employment.

Emphasizing the need for a sustainable and creative campaign to operate teaching and research activities, internationalization initiatives, and the development of physical infrastructure and colleges, Prime Minister Prachanda affirmed his commitment to the growth and success of the University of Agriculture and Forestry.

Established in 2010, the university addresses the demand for a technical institution dedicated to studying, researching, and developing technology in agriculture, veterinary medicine, fisheries, animal science, forestry, and natural resource management.

Obstacles on iron mine resumption disappoint locals in Parbat

RSS
Parbat, Jan.31

The long closure of the iron mine in Mahashila rural municipality-6, Parbat, has left the locals disappointed. The mine has been inoperative since the year 2007 BS, and locals express dissatisfaction with the apparent lack of concern from relevant authorities regarding the reopening of the mine.

Despite a three-year effort by a squad from the Department of Mines and Geology in Lainchaur to excavate the mine, there has been no significant progress reported so far.

During their study, the team of geologists used electrical resistivity technology and discovered a substantial presence of iron ore in various locations—some on the surface and some beneath the earth. The ore mine spans an area of two kilometers.

Local youth, Jeevan Bikram Uchchai, said that there seems to be a lack of priority for further exploration of the mine.

The Department and Nepal Parbat Ore Mine Industry on 23 December, 2010 explored ways to resuming the mine's operation. The mine is situated 40 kilometers away from the district headquarters Kushma Bazar.

The rural municipality has shown its interest in operating the mine lately. Locals share that the implements made from the iron extracted from this mine 73 years ago could be bought and seen in use even until 1984.

According to the elders, unlike the iron ore mined in other places the iron ore found here does not need to be refined. The ore extracted from the mine can be directly melted to manufacture the different tools and ware. Prem Bahadur Sunar, a local, said the extraction was stopped at the mine later for lack of coal supply.

The home-made implements manufactured using the iron extracted from this mine used to be sold in various villages in Baglung, Palpa and Syngja among other districts.

The iron used in the cables for building bridges over the rivers in Parbat and surrounding places also came from this iron mine. The bridges using the cables made out of iron from this mine can still be seen at Modibeni and Jaimini Ghat.

It is said that around 400 households used to eke out a living extracting iron ore from this mine and selling it until five decades back. The ward chair BK said the village itself is named Phalam Khani (iron mine) owing to the large number of iron mines throughout the village.

According to him, operation of the mine here would contribute to the country's economy and scores of youths will get employment. "We are compelled to use imported iron and steel due to the inability to operate the mine that is eight at our doorstep," lamented Bal Bahadur Chhetri, a local.

Europe's economic pain drags on with zero growth at the end of last year

AP
Frankfurt, Germany, Jan. 31

Europe's economy failed to expand at the end of 2023, dragging out the stagnation for more than a year amid higher energy prices, costlier credit and a downturn in former powerhouse Germany.

Zero economic growth for the October-to-December period of last year follows a 0.1% contraction in the three months before that, according to figures released Tuesday by EU statistics agency Eurostat.

That extends a miserable run of economic blahs: The 20 countries that use the euro currency have not shown significant growth since the third quarter of 2022, when the economy grew 0.5%.

And the start of this year looks no better, with indicators of business activity still flashing red for contraction.

Plus, disruptions to shipping in the Red Sea have constricted global trade through the Suez Canal, a major route between Asia and Europe, surging shipping costs and threatening to boost inflation.

The new figures underlined the growing divide between Europe and the United States, whose economy grew 0.8% in the fourth quarter compared with the previous three-month period, or an annual pace of 3.3% — better than expected.

The eurozone grew 0.5% for the full year, while the U.S. grew 2.5%.

"The big picture is that eurozone GDP has been flat since the third quarter of 2022 when gas prices surged and the ECB started raising interest rates," Jack Allen-Reynolds, deputy chief eurozone economist at Capital Economics, said in a written analysis.

Not all the news is bad. For one thing, unemployment is at record lows and the number of jobs rose in the July-to-September quarter.

Energy prices also have come down from recent spikes — though they remain higher than before Russia invaded Ukraine — and storage levels of natural gas, which is used to heat homes, power factories and generate electricity, are robust.

With gas storage 72% full and most of the winter heating season nearly over, fears of higher utility bills and another energy crisis have eased.

While the economy has stagnated, inflation also has declined rapidly from its painful double-digit peak, falling to 2.9% in December.

But people's pay and purchasing power are still catching up to the levels lost through the price surge.

It's seen as French farmers pushing for better pay, fewer constraints and lower costs have set up barricades around Paris this week.

Meanwhile, the anti-inflation medicine applied by the European Central Bank — sharply higher interest rates — has curbed business investment and real estate activity like construction and home sales.

TITLE AND LOGO OF THIRD INVESTMENT SUMMIT FINALISED

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

The logo and title of the third investment summit that Nepal is hosting on coming April 28 and 29 have been finalised.

The event has been named 'Emerging Nepal Summit- 2024', according to the Summit Secretariat. The second meeting of the Investment Summit Steering Committee decided the title of the event, according to Secretariat joint-secretary and Investment Board Spokesperson Pradyumna Prasad Upadhyay.

The Steering Committee coordinated by the Finance Minister, the Implementation Committee led by the Chief Secretary, and the Technical Committee headed by the Secretary at the Ministry of Industry, Commerce, and Supplies have been formed in view of hosting the event. The Summit's Secretariat coordinated by the IBN Chief Executive Officer is located at the Office of the Investment Board.

A taskforce formed to recommend legal amendments for the Summit has proposed amendments to around one dozen of acts and regulations. As the pre-event of the Summit, the OIBN last Friday held a workshop on 'Unlocking Nepal's Investment Potential: Collaborative Strategies for Economic Growth,' in Kathmandu.

NEA cuts off power to street lights in Bardibas



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bardibas, Jan. 31

The Gaushala Distribution Centre of Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has started cutting street lights at the five local levels of the district. According to the Gaushala Distribution Centre, after the municipalities refused to pay the arrears despite repeated requests, they started cutting off the lights as a last resort.

Mayor of the Municipality has been saying that no matter what NEA does, the office is unable to pay the dues in the current situation.

According to the NEA, Gaushala, the five local levels have to pay Rs. 17.2 million dues for the street lights as of July 16, 2023.

The Authority has shown the highest arrears of Rs. 6.5 million of Bardibas Municipality. According to the Account section of the distribution centre, Rs. 4.7 million arrears need to be collected from Bhangaha Municipality, Rs. 2.4 million from Aurahi Municipality, Rs. 1.9 million from Sonma Rural Municipality and Rs. 1.5 million from Gaushala Municipality.

According to Jagannath Jha, Head of Gaushala Distribution Centre, the Authority has been requesting the municipalities in writing since before Dashain festival to pay the street lighting arrears.

"We sent separate letters giving 45-day time in October to pay the street light charges. After it was not heeded, the municipalities were again asked to pay the arrears in November. We sent a written request again," Jha said.

"After the request was ignored, the NEA is forced to start the process of cutting off the lights," said Jha. Gaushala Distribution Centre has so far cut off more than 300 street lights after arrears were not paid in time. The local levels have, however, alleged that the local office failed to pay the fees after the NEA did not come to collect the money in time.

The chiefs of the local bodies have been expressing their displeasure with the cutting power supply of street lights and with the obligation of paying the arrears even before they were elected.

Prahlad Chhetri, mayor of Bardibas Municipality, which has the highest arrears, said that such a huge amount cannot be paid in the current condition. "The NEA itself is the first to blame for the accumulation in arrears," he said.

IMF sketches a brighter view of global economy seeing lower inflation

AP
Washington, Jan. 31

The International Monetary Fund has upgraded its outlook for the world economy this year, envisioning resilient growth led by the United States and a slower pace of inflation.

In its latest outlook, the 190-country lending agency said Tuesday that it now expects the global economy to grow 3.1% this year, unchanged from 2023 but better than the 2.9% it had predicted for 2024 in its previous estimate in October.

Worldwide, the IMF thinks inflation will ease from 6.8% in 2023 to 5.8% in 2024 and 4.4% in 2025. In the most advanced economies, the agency expects inflation to drop this year to 2.6% and next year to the 2% level that the Federal Reserve and some other central banks have set as a target.

The combination of steady growth



and falling inflation has raised hopes for a so-called soft landing for the global economy – a slowdown sufficient to contain inflation without causing a recession.

"We are now in the final descent toward a soft landing," Pierre-Olivier Gourinchas, the IMF's chief economist, told reporters ahead of the report's release.

The forecast for overall global growth this year and next (3.2%) trails the 3.8% average from 2000 to 2019. That is partly because the Fed and other central banks aggressively raised interest rates to fight high inflation, and the resulting higher borrowing costs have slowed spending and investment.

Gourinchas said he expects "relatively limited" economic damage from the attacks by Yemen-based Houthi rebels on shipping in the Red Sea. The attacks have forced container ships carrying cargo between Asia and Europe to avoid the Suez Canal and instead take the long way around the tip of Africa, thereby delaying and disrupting shipments and raising freight charges.

But Gourinchas said that for now, the Red Sea disruptions don't seem to be "a major source of reigniting supply side inflation," which arose from far more severe shipping backlogs in 2021 and 2022.

For the United States, the world's largest economy, the IMF sharply marked up its estimate for growth this year – to 2.1% from the 1.5% it had penciled in three months ago. The U.S. economy expanded 2.5% in 2023 after an unexpected burst of year-end growth fueled by consumers willing to spend despite higher borrowing costs.

The outlook for the slumping Chinese economy was also upgraded by the IMF. It now expects the world's second-biggest economy to grow 4.6% this year, up from the 4.2% it had forecast in October but down from 5.2% growth in 2023. Government spending has helped offset the damage from a collapse in the Chinese housing market.

"There was a lot of resilience in many, many parts of the world," Gourinchas said, singling out Brazil, India, Southeast Asia and Russia, which has remained surprisingly sturdy in the face of Western sanctions imposed after its invasion of Ukraine.

But the IMF downgraded the outlook for some places. Europe, for example, continues to struggle with dispirited consumers and the lingering effects of the energy price shock caused by the Russian invasion of Ukraine. The IMF expects the 20 countries that share the euro currency to collectively grow a meager 0.9% this year.

NPC elicits recommendations from development partners

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

The National Planning Commission (NPC) held consultations with international development partners on the draft of the 16th period plan and Least Developed Country (LDC) graduation smooth transition strategy.

At a discussion held under the chair of NPC Vice-Chair Dr Min Bahadur Shrestha on Tuesday, officials from the United Nations, World Bank, International Monetary Fund as well as Ambassadors and representatives from different countries had provided their recommendations.

United Nations Resident Representative Hanna Singar Hamdy and Ambassador of Finland to Nepal Riina-Riikka Heikka are jointly chairing the Nepal-based International Development Partners Group (IDPG). UN Resident Representative Hamdy said Nepal would enter the next chapter of development after LDC graduation.

> NPC Vice-Chair Dr Shrestha said constructive recommendations received from the development partners would be included in the 16th plan.

Other development partners attending the meeting stressed the need to establish coherent linkage between the 16th plan and LDC graduation strategy.

NPC Vice-Chair Dr Shrestha said constructive recommendations received from the development partners would be included in the 16th plan. Earlier, NPC had held discussion with newly-appointed members of the National Development Council in regard to the 16th plan.

Mobile camp launched in Shahidbhoomi

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhankuta, Jan. 31

Shahidbhoomi Rural Municipality in Dhankuta has launched integrated mobile camps to extend essential services to the people by reaching out to various villages.

Manoj Rai, Rural Municipality Chairman, informed that the rural municipality recently organised a one-day satellite clinic at Dhap in Ward No. 1 on January 28. The clinic focused on long-term family planning services, including a one-day satellite clinic providing Intrauterine Contraceptive Device (IUCD) and implant services.

While the primary goal is to serve children, the elderly, and disabled citizens in all seven wards of the municipality, mobile camps have been conducted in each ward to provide services to all citizens, Rai said. On the first day camp in Dhap, over 250 patients received health check-ups, 20 individuals were issued disability identity cards and 32 senior citizens received blankets.

As of Tuesday, the camp examined 208 individuals for their health, issued disability identity cards to 44 people out of the 140 tested for disability and distributed blankets to 111 senior citizens aged between 80 and 84 years. In addition to distributing general health equipment to communities and clubs, 15 stretchers, and services such as VIA examination and family planning were extended to 68 individuals, excluding those with disabilities.

Considering the winter conditions, blankets were also distributed to senior citizens during the camp. Medical Superintendent of Dhankuta District Hospital Dr. Amitabh Thakur, along with a team of doctors, conducted examinations for cervical cancer, breast cancer, organ failure, etc.

The camp was held at Chhintang Sambu village health post on January 29, Khoku health post on 30, and is scheduled to conclude with a tour camp at the ward office and Chamcha Community Health Unit on the 31.

The initiative demonstrates the municipality's commitment to providing comprehensive health services and support to its residents, fostering community well-being and healthcare accessibility.



PHOTO: TRN

Shahidbhoomi Rural Municipality officials providing essential goods and services of the winter season to the needy people in the integrated mobile camp in Dhankuta, Wednesday.

Contractor delays road construction in Surkhet

BY NAVIN SUBEDI
Surkhet, Jan. 31

The construction of a road connecting Mangalgadhi and Kakrebihar of Birendranagar in Surket has not been completed for years due to negligence of the contractor.

The incomplete road, also a route to the famous Hindu-Buddhist temple of Kakrebihar, has adversely affected locals and travellers. It becomes dusty during sunny days and muddy during rainy season.

Lokendra Bhatta, who had come to visit Kakrebihar from Kathmandu on Friday, expressed sadness over the condition of the road connecting the main market areas and the popular tourist destination. He questioned whether the situation was due to negligence of the government or the contractor.

Locals are frustrated as dust reaches their houses and courtyards when vehicles pass by. Dal Bahadur Khatri, a local, said, "For more than two years, our houses have been covered in dust. When will we get rid of it?"

Amar Sisne Nepal Megha JV Nepalgunj was awarded with the contract of the construction of 2.4 kilometre road at a cost of 127.6 million on November 20, 2021 to be completed by mid-July 2023. However, even half the work could not be completed until then.

According to the Infrastructure Development Directorate, Surkhet, only 43 per cent physical progress has been made so far.

The provincial government has faced significant criticism due to the delay in construction. The deadline has been extended till mid-March, 2024 but no work is being carried out at present.

Sub-engineer at the Infrastructure Development Directorate, Surkhet Prem Chandra Pandey said that the construction work was delayed due to the negligence of the construction company. He said, "Although necessary materials are in place, work has not progressed as expected. We have informed them that if the work continues to be delayed, legal action will be taken, and they have assured us that they will expedite the work soon."

Meanwhile, the construction company had already collected around Rs. 20 million. Sub-engineer Pandey said that although the locals had protested in the initial phase, there was no dispute regarding the road so far.

Additionally, construction work of more than a dozen main roads in the province entrusted to Kancharam Construction has been delayed. The construction company belonging to Purna Bahadur Tamang (Kancharam), elected as the House of Representatives member from the Nepali Congress, took the contract for black topping13 different roads on September 2, 2021. The contract was signed with the Infrastructure Development Directorate, Surkhet at a cost of Rs. 129.4 million with a deadline of March 12, 2023.

The contract included the construction of roads along Itram School-Traffic Office, Gharelu Office-Hotline road, Gharelu-Uphill road, Provincial Assembly-Nepal Telecom, Gurung Chowk road, Kalinchowk-Itram and others.

The construction company has only constructed drainage and graveled six roads so far. The construction of the rest of the roads has not even started.

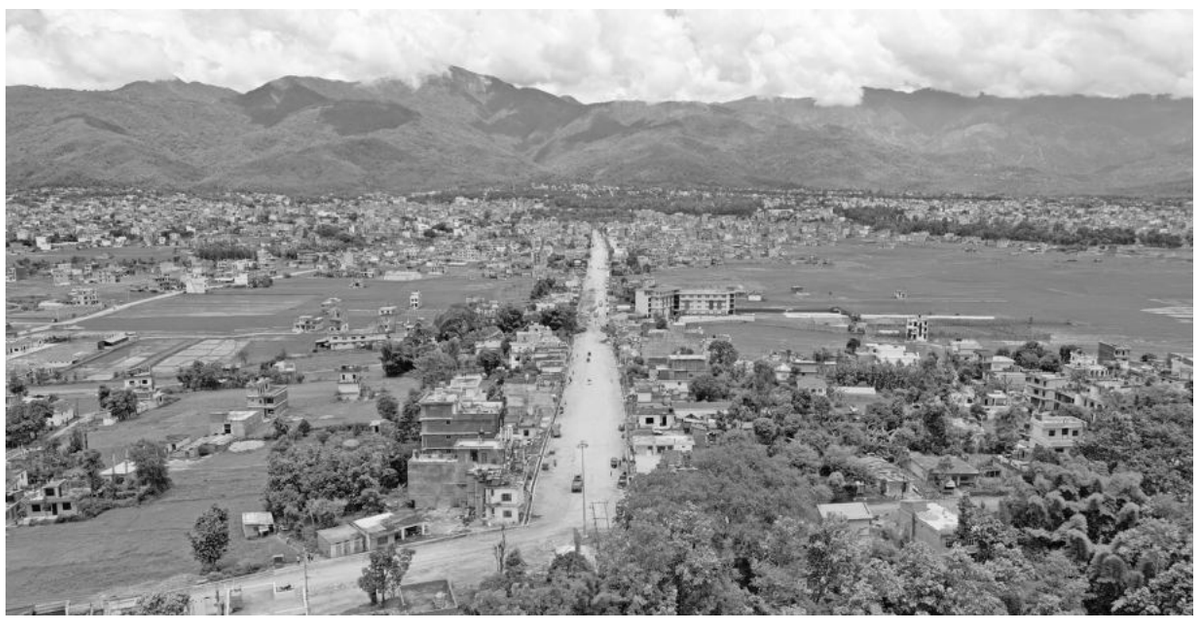


PHOTO: NAVIN SUBEDI/TRN

A beautiful scene of Latikoili settlement in Surkhet.

GORKHAPATRA JOURNALIST PANDIT PASSES AWAY



PHOTO: TRN

Late Sheshkanta Pandit

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

Associate Editor of Gorkhapatra Daily Sheshkanta P andit passed away on Wednesday. He was 47.

A cancer patient, Pandit breathed his last while undergoing treatment at Mediciti Hospital, Lalipur, according to his brother Srikanta Pandit.

Born in Bhanu Municipality, Tanahun in 1976, Pandit had joined the Gorkhapatra daily as a Kathmandu Valley correspondent in 2003 and got permanent status as a reporter in 2008.

His last rites were performed at Pashupati Aryaghat on Wednesday.

He is survived by his wife, one son and one daughter.

The Rising Nepal family pays tribute to Pandit, wishing eternal peace of the departed soul.

NHRC TO MAKE REPORT PUBLIC EVERY SIX MONTHS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) has started making public the decisions taken by the Commission after investigating the registered complaints once in every six months from fiscal year 2023/24.

The Commission said that a total of 58 complaints related to human rights violations were registered in the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

The investigation was conducted on 117 complaints, including those registered during this period and previous years.

According to the periodic report of the Commission, during this period, the final decisions were taken on 44 cases while 37 cases were recommended for action and compensation and seven were dismissed.

Two martyrs of Dhanusha missing in martyrs' list

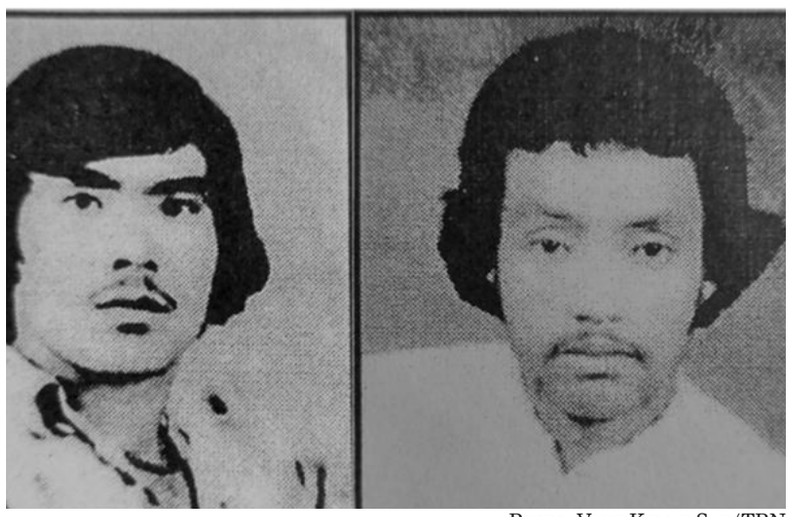


PHOTO: VIJAY KUMAR SAH/TRN

Residents express distress over the oversight of the names of Ishwar Lama and Padam Lama, martyrs from Umaprempur in Dhanushadham Municipality-6, Dhanusha, from the official list of the martyrs.

BY VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Jan. 31

Martyrs' Week concluded on Wednesday, marking the end of a nationwide commemoration held from January 24 to January 30. The week honoured the martyrs who sacrificed their lives for the freedom and rights of the country and its people.

The Martyrs Week was commemorated by organising various programmes to honour the contributions of the martyrs who sacrificed their lives during the Rana rule, the autocratic Panchayat system, and various rights-based and democratic movements thereafter.

Despite the nationwide celebration of Martyrs' Day, there is a prevailing sentiment among locals that the state has neglected two martyrs from Dhanusha. Residents express sorrow over the oversight of the names of Ishwar Lama and Padam Lama, martyrs from Umaprempur in Dhanushadham Municipality-6, Dhanusha, from the official list of the martyrs.

Rajkumar Lama, the brother of Ishwar, said that Ishwar and Padam's names were excluded from the list of martyrs due to their inability to reach the government. He mentioned that he has been urging the top leaders of political parties to facilitate meetings with residents, aiming to ensure the inclusion of both names in the list of martyrs.

According to him, both Ishwar and Padam were involved in the agitation against the panchayat system in 1985, during which the then panchayat rulers allegedly killed them and disposed of their bodies. They were participating in the Satyagraha movement initiated by the Nepali Congress in 1985 and were arrested on May 24 same year.

He mentioned that an investigation report regarding Ishwar Lama and Padam Lama indicates that the panchayat administration was responsible for their deaths, allegedly killing them and disposing of their bodies under the guise of arrest, transferring them to different camps, temporary jails and police offices.

Before that, Ishwar had been arrested and imprisoned for over six years for his involvement in the armed struggle waged by Bisheshwar Prasad Koirala in 1974. During that period, he was charged with a political case, under which one used to be served a life penalty or life imprisonment.

Ishwar was released from prison on April 13, 1980, following a general amnesty. Upon his release, top Congress leaders including BP Koirala, Ganesh Man Singh, Krishna Prasad Bhattarai, and Mahendra Narayan Nidhi worked tirelessly to strengthen the party organisation and broaden the movement.

A study report said that, after the death of BP Koirala in 1982, Ishwar was actively engaged in political campaigns in the district. During this period, he also served as an executive member of the District Congress in Dhanusha.

Ishwar was 29 years old, and Padam was 30 years old when they were arrested by the Panchayat administration in 1985. Locals allege that their names were omitted from the list of martyrs due to a lack of accessibility.

Former minister Paudel dies in road mishap

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nawalpur, Jan. 31

Former minister of Bagmati Province Bala Ram Paudel was killed in a road accident along the East-West Highway on Tuesday.

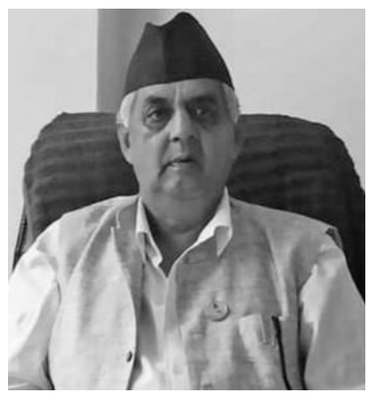
According to Police Inspector Hasta Bahadur Sunar, a bus with registration Ba 1 Kha 8547 hit former minister Bala Ram Paudel's motorcycle while he was returning his home in Chitwan.

The former minister who was coming to Gaindakot on his motorcycle with registration number Na 46 Pa 7759 was hit by the bus heading towards Nawalpur from Pokhara, said Inspector Sunar. Paudel was a permanent resident of Bharatpur Municipality-17, Chitwan. He was 63.

According to the police, Paudel, who was admitted to the Bharatpur Hospital, was pronounced dead while undergoing treatment.

Paudel was appointed Minister for Land Management, Cooperatives and Poverty Alleviation of Bagmati Province on December 24, 2021. He was also a General Committee member of the Nepali Congress.

Police have detained the bus driver Bishnu Bahadur Kami, 26, of Rainas Municipality-2 of Lamjung, for further investigation, said SP Bedh Bahadur Paudel.



FILE PHOTO: TRN

Late Bala Ram Paudel

Nepal Electricity Authority
Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate
Durbar Marga, Kathmandu, Nepal

Invitation for Electronic Bids

(First Date of Publication : 01 February 2024)

IFB No.	Description	Price of Bid Document	Bid Security Amount	Last Date & Time of Bid Submission/Opening
ICB/DCSD-080/81-02	Supply and Delivery of Steel Tubular Poles for Koshi, Madhesh and Bagmati Province	NPR 20,000.00	NPR 1,40,00,00,000.00	2024 March 18, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 18, 13:00 Hrs
ICB/DCSD-080/81-03	Supply and Delivery of Steel Tubular Poles for Gandaki, Lumbini, Karnali and Sudur Paschim Province	NPR 20,000.00	NPR 1,30,00,00,000.00	2024 March 18, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 18, 13:30 Hrs
ICB/DCSD-080/81-10	Supply and Delivery of Low Voltage Aerial Bunched Cable for Koshi and Madhesh Province	NPR 20,000.00	USD 50,000.00	2024 March 19, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 19, 13:00 Hrs
ICB/DCSD-080/81-11	Supply and Delivery of Low Voltage Aerial Bunched Cable for Bagmati and Gandaki Province	NPR 20,000.00	USD 65,000.00	2024 March 19, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 19, 13:30 Hrs
ICB/DCSD-080/81-12	Supply and Delivery of Low Voltage Aerial Bunched Cable for Lumbini, Karnali and Sudur Paschim Province	NPR 20,000.00	USD 38,000.00	2024 March 19, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 19, 14:00 Hrs
ICB/DCSD-080/81-13	Supply and Delivery of Medium Voltage Covered Conductor for Koshi and Madhesh Province	NPR 20,000.00	USD 100,000.00	2024 March 20, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 20, 13:00 Hrs
ICB/DCSD-080/81-14	Supply and Delivery of Medium Voltage Covered Conductor for Bagmati and Gandaki Province	NPR 20,000.00	USD 65,000.00	2024 March 20, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 20, 13:30 Hrs
ICB/DCSD-080/81-15	Supply and Delivery of Medium Voltage Covered Conductor for Lumbini, Karnali and Sudur Paschim Province	NPR 20,000.00	USD 40,000.00	2024 March 20, 12:00 Hrs 2024 March 20, 14:00 Hrs

For Further details, please visit PPMO's e-GP system: **www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp**

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Strive not to be a success, but rather to be of value.

-- Albert Einstein

EDITORIAL

Containing Corruption

Corruption is one of the systemic malaises that has hit multiple sectors ranging from governance and development to the public service delivery. Corruption is an abuse of public authority to fulfill individual interests. It is pervasive and vicious, occurring in different forms and layers. In whatever form and scale it happens, it drains the taxpayers' money and fuels inequality in the society. Corruption taking place at political, legal and policy-level has wider ramifications. In a poor country like Nepal, there is a nefarious nexus between politicians, bureaucrats and business persons behind the corruption scams of grand scale. For instance, such a connivance came to the fore in the exposure of notorious Lalita Niwas scam and fake Bhutanese refugee scandals in which top level political leaders, bureaucrats and middlemen were involved.

Major corruption cases do not take place without the support of politicians in the seat of power. The politicians holding public offices are often involved in policy-level corruption that is not caught by even a long hand of law. There are instances in which courts and anti-graft agencies do not target those, who are reportedly involved in the policy-level malfeasance. It is said that policy-level corruption is made at the government level. But, what is equally disturbing is the legal corruption in which legal provisions are framed or bent to protect the corrupt. The political parties, civil society and media often talk about curbing corruption but the anti-corruption campaign has not yielded desired outcomes. On the contrary, the tentacles of corruption keeps on growing.

Nepal's unifier Prithvi Narayan Shah stated that both bribe givers as well as bribe takers are the enemies of the country. But the bribery and embezzlement account for the bulk of the corruption cases in the country. Corruption has been a structural problem that gets entrenched due to moral decay and insatiable greed for power and wealth by hook or by crook. Political and economic malfunctions are attributed to systemic corruption that cause harm to society at the macro level. The country has installed various mechanisms and agencies to fight corruption but ironically, corruption cases are reported frequently.

A news report, carried by this daily on Wednesday, says that Nepal has slightly improved its standing in the global Corruption Perception Index (CPI) 2023. It has jumped from 110th among 180 countries in 2022 to 108th position in 2023. However, the Transparency International's CPI 2023 report launched globally on Tuesday, puts Nepal in the group of high corruption perception with just 35 score in 100. Its score has climbed to 35 this year from 34 last year. Nepal belongs to a group of two-thirds of nations that attained less than 50. This amply implies that Nepal should intensify its efforts and step up actions to check corruption and achieve good governance.

In south Asia, Bhutan tops the list and remains at the 26th position. India is in 93rd, Sri Lanka 115th, Pakistan 133rd, Bangladesh 149th and Afghanistan 162nd. Strong rule of law and well-functioning democratic institutions discourage the cases of corruption. The TI states that the fight for justice and the fight against corruption should go hand in hand because where the justice system fails to uphold the rule of law, corruption thrives. It is necessary to strengthen the anti-graft bodies to effectively implement the laws designed to punish the corrupt.

Cultivating Reading Habit

SUGAM GAUTAM

At various gatherings and during festivals, my relatives and neighbours barrage me with a string of questions about literature. Their primary concern revolves around the rewards and outcomes of my devotion to reading and writing. While they nod approvingly at my answers, I sense that deep down, they perceive my passion as merely a way to pass the time. Only those acutely keen on literature can truly understand why I am always immersed in newspapers and novels. In my case, not a single day passes without flipping through a newspaper or leafing through a novel. Some of my friends find it taxing to sit at a table with books laid out in front of them. In contrast, I can continue reading endlessly, sometimes to the point where they need to conspire to get me away from the table.

My passion for literature did not burst forth suddenly. As I reflect on my childhood, I vividly recall events that suggest I had an uncanny grace for reading books. As a child, I would borrow books from my neighbour friends who had an abundance of them in the well-resourced library of their schools. In return, I would offer something that captivated their interest. This prolonged exchange between books and other items allowed me to develop an eye for discovering beauty in written texts. During those days, I read children's books written in Nepali, and over time, I delved into English literature, which I found to be the most enjoyable. By now, I have read hundreds of books, and I can proudly say that cultivating the habit of reading is the best thing I have done in my life.

One strange observation among readers is that each reader has their own favorite genre and writers. Some may prefer self-help books to enhance productivity, while others may choose fictional novels to wash away their weariness. Regardless of the genre, readers are filled with knowledge and an understanding of diverse cultures. Self-help books inspire good living habits, promoting health and contentment. Books on politics and history provide accounts of the country's transformations over time. As a fiction reader, I enjoy delving into the psychology of characters, allowing me to understand complex human sentiments. Strangely, over the years, my reading habit has transformed me into a compassionate being with an easy-going personality.

Reading not only enhances one's personality but also boosts communication skills. My writing continues to improve with each book I read, significantly benefiting my academic pursuits. The benefits one can derive from reading books are limitless, and it is a must for people of every age, irrespective of their gender or profession. If someone claims they can't read due to a busy schedule, they must know the fact that business tycoons like Warren Buffet and Bill Gates also make time to read books of their interests. While forming a daily reading habit can be challenging, one can start by reading at least 10 pages a day and gradually increase the number of pages. Children who enjoy scrolling through phones should be introduced to books, as this life-altering habit can sow a healthy seed for the future.

Can Artificial Intelligence Resolve Disputes?

Mukti Rijal



We are now living in an era of fourth industrial revolution characterised by a fusion of technologies that is blurring the lines between the physical, digital and biological spheres. First coined by Klaus Schwab, founder and executive chairman of the World Economic Forum, fourth Industrial revolution era, unlike the previous first, second and third industrial revolutions, is dominated by artificial intelligence (AI), which is radically altering many professions. While it led to the decline of some traditional jobs, it created new opportunities in digital marketing, web development, and data science. Least developed countries like Nepal will have to countenance the implications of fourth industrial revolution as the developed nations will have to.

Fourth industrial revolution will have far-reaching implications on almost every aspect of our daily life, affecting how we interact with technology, and transforming where and how work is done. It is ushering into a fully connected digital age as a result of leaps in computer power and efficiency in terms of data gathering, analysis, and decision - and prediction-making capabilities. This article will talk about the AI implications on alternative dispute resolution, especially mediation, with reference to an article titled "Will AI replace Mediators" by Robert Bergman for mediate.com - a web based widely acclaimed e- resources in alternative dispute resolution (ADR) field .

AI in Mediation

While AI technology's integration into various sectors has historically oscillated between replacing and creating jobs, its role in dispute resolution through mediation raises unique questions about the balance between human empathy and machine efficiency. Mediation as dispute resolution technique relies on human attributes such as empathy, emotional intelligence, and the ability to navigate complex social dynamics. These skills are crucial in understanding the subtleties of conflict and facilitating resolutions that are acceptable to the parties involved in the disputes. However, as mentioned in the above referred article, we now live in a world of interruptions, information overload, misinformation, too many false choices, biases and especially mobile phone and social media addiction.

The use of social media has left us particularly vulnerable to confirmation bias, or the propensity to choose evidences that shores up our prior beliefs. Can AI, with its current capabilities, mitigate the bad effects of social media influence and replace the inherently human skills needed for successful mediation is a moot point. Historically, technological advancements have both displaced and created jobs. The industrial revolutions in the past replaced many manual jobs but created new opportunities in factories and industries. In the realm of AI, we see a similar pattern. AI has replaced some jobs, particularly those involving repetitive tasks, but has also created new roles, such as AI trainers and ethicists.

In mediation, AI's role has been more about transformation than replacement. According to Robert Bergman, tools like predictive analytics and automated negotiation algorithms like SmartSettle One, Negobot, Modria, etc. have assisted mediators, particularly in collaborative negotiation, rather than replacing them. Rather than replace the mediator, the AI-assisted tools help the mediator to generate and analyse questionnaires, understand disputing party priorities, and suggest potential areas for negotiation. Despite its advancements, AI in mediation faces significant challenges as well. One of the primary limitations is its inability to fully understand and interpret human emotions and cultural nuances.

> Integrating AI in mediation serves to augment, rather than undermine, the human element that is so vital to conflict resolution.

AI systems are also only as good as the data they are trained on, which can lead to biased outcomes if the data is not diverse and comprehensive. Furthermore, AI's decision-making processes like recognising patterns and correlation can be opaque, leading to trust and credibility issues. In AI, hallucination can occur when the AI model generates output that is not supported by any known facts. This can happen due to errors or inadequacies in the training data or biases in the model itself. A big disadvantage of AI is that it cannot learn to think outside the box. AI is capable of learning over time with prefed data and past experiences but cannot be creative in its approach.

The integration of AI in mediation also brings legal and ethical considerations to the forefront. Questions about accountability, especially in cases of flawed AI-mediated decisions, are paramount. The legal framework governing AI's role in mediation is still in its nascent stages, requiring careful consideration of issues like data privacy, consent and liability. Although there is a beginning of worldwide effort to regulate AI, we are far from having an agreed upon framework. Different nations harbour varied perspectives on the deployment and control of AI technologies, influenced by their unique socio-political and economic contexts.

Ethical frameworks

Addressing these ethical considerations requires a collaborative effort among AI developers, mediators, ethicists, and legal professionals. The development and implementation of AI in mediation should be guided by ethical frameworks and standards that prioritise fairness, transparency, and respect for human dignity, argues Robert Bergman. Rather than outright replacement, a more likely scenario is AI transforming the role of mediators. AI and decision analytics can handle certain tasks like preliminary data gathering, analysing documents, understanding priorities, identifying areas for negotiation, or drafting initial settlement proposals. This integration allows human mediators to focus on more complex aspects of the mediation process, such as understanding emotional undercurrents and building trust among parties.

While AI brings efficiency and a data-driven approach to mediation, it is not poised to replace human mediators entirely. The current limitations of AI in understanding the full spectrum of human emotions and cultural contexts, coupled with legal and ethical concerns, suggest a future where AI acts more as an assistant than a replacement. The evolution of AI in mediation is likely to follow the historical pattern of technology reshaping rather than eradicating jobs, leading to a transformed landscape where human mediators leverage AI for enhanced effectiveness and reach. As this field evolves, continuous evaluation and adaptation will be crucial in ensuring that integrating AI in mediation serves to augment, rather than undermine, the human element that is so vital to conflict resolution.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

Bolster Justice System To Punish Fake Babas

Anupam Bhattarai



Many religious customs and activities have their roots in Nepal, a country rich in spirituality and culture. Of all the spiritual leaders, religious gurus or "babas" are highly respected in society. Although many of these babas are highly regarded for their teachings and contributions to their followers' spiritual development, there has been increasing worry about those who take advantage of their position for personal gain, which has caused a great deal of trouble for Nepal's criminal justice system. The country's criminal justice system has a major problem as there is rising worry about the darker side of some of these spiritual leaders, even while many of them sincerely lead their followers on a road of enlightenment and self-discovery.

There has been an increase in the number of babas in Nepal in recent years. These individuals claim to have supernatural abilities and provide spiritual counsel to their followers. With their promises of medical miracles, spiritual enlightenment, and answers to life's difficulties, these babas frequently draw sizable followings. Regrettably, the surge in criminal activity linked to these self-proclaimed gurus has coincided with their popularity. Numerous religious traditions have a long history, and babas are ingrained in the country's culture. These spiritual leaders provide instruction to a large number of individuals who are looking for comfort and purpose in their life. But the explosion of self-styled babas has produced a complicated situation in which legitimate spiritual leaders live side by side with others who abuse their position.

Unsettling stories

While the majority of babas legitimately commit themselves to spiritual endeavours, there have been occasions when select individuals exploit their position for financial gain, power, and even participate in criminal actions. Spiritual leaders' reputations have been tarnished by documented cases of fraud, sexual exploitation, and power abuse. Allegations against several babas range from indulging in illicit activities and spreading superstitions to financial theft and sexual abuse. Some babas have faced allegations of financially and emotionally abusing their adherents, preying on their susceptibility while seeking spiritual comfort. The fact that sexual exploitation and abuse of minors occurs often in their ashrams, or spiritual communities, is among the most unsettling features of the dark side of certain babas in Nepal.

There have been reports of sexual harassment and abuse of followers — often women and children — occurring on the pretext of spiritual activities. Ensuring victim protection while prosecuting these accused perpetrators is a difficult task for the criminal justice system. Unsettling stories have surfaced of babas abusing and sexually abusing their devotees. By manipulating the confidence entrusted to them, these people have exploited weak followers, causing trauma and psychological suffering in their wake. The judicial process is complicated by victims' unwillingness to come forward, frequently because of cultural shame.

> To address the issues faced by exploitative babas, there is a need for legislative reforms that expressly target violations within the religious and spiritual sector.

In order to handle the problems associated with babas, the criminal justice system must overcome a number of obstacles. It is difficult to look into and prosecute these cases since criminal activity and spiritual beliefs are entwined. Furthermore, certain babas have power in social and political circles, which makes the judicial process much more difficult. The complexity of the offenses connected to some babas poses difficulties for criminal justice system. The difficulties in obtaining evidence in situations involving spiritual topics, insufficient legal frameworks, and improper regulation all add to the complexity of dealing with these issues.

Furthermore, there are extra challenges in the investigation and prosecution procedures because of the deeply ingrained cultural reverence for spiritual leaders. To address the issues faced by exploitative babas, there is a need for legislative reforms that expressly target violations within the religious and spiritual sector. Public awareness efforts that are more widespread can enable supporters to identify and report instances of exploitation. Working together, civic society, religious organisations, and law enforcement authorities may develop a stronger framework to deal with these problems.

Public awareness

The growth of babas has resulted in both criminal issues and spiritual enlightenment. Although many spiritual leaders do truly benefit society, the criminal justice system must move quickly to address and suppress the criminal activity connected to some babas. To find a balance between honoring spiritual beliefs and promoting public awareness, it is imperative to strengthen legal frameworks, ensure effective regulation, and achieving a balance between upholding spiritual beliefs and shielding people from exploitation and abuse requires strengthening legal frameworks, making sure regulations are effective, and raising public awareness. Nepal can only negotiate the complex terrain of spirituality while defending the rights and welfare of its people by working together.

Although babas are an important part of Nepal's spiritual scene, the growing number of people who are committing crimes while disguising their actions as spiritual presents a severe threat to the criminal justice system. Ensuring justice for victims while maintaining religious liberties necessitates a multifaceted strategy that includes legal reforms, public awareness campaigns, and cooperative efforts from several parties. Resolving this issue is essential for the health of those impacted as well as for maintaining the integrity of the spiritual traditions that are very significant to Nepali culture.

(The author is an advocate. @attanupam)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 1, 1974

Loans To Be Provided To Schools

Bhaktapur, Jan. 31: The District Education Committee has decided to give loans to secondary, lower secondary and primary schools of the district, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

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Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Public-Private Partnership Crucial

I am writing in reference to a news report titled, "*Govt. will collaborate with private sector: PM Prachanda*" published in online version of this daily on Jan. 29.

The Government and private sectors are a part of national economy.

Though they differ in their structure and principles, the collaboration between public and private sectors can be useful to the nation.

As of today, Nepal is still a developing nation. In the past decades, it saw a rise in political instability.

Comparatively, today the current government seems to be quite stable.

Although there have been adversities, the government has upheld its democratic values.

Even the private sectors have seen a boost in economy which is improving over the effects of several years of the pandemic.

The government can promote the private sector even more by enhancing import and export policies of the nation.



Govt. will collaborate with private sector: PM Prachanda

Share — Change Font Size: A A A

Simara, Jan 29: Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said the government would move ahead collaborating with the private sector.

In an interaction with local entrepreneurs after inspecting Jitpursimara sub-metropolis-based Special Economic Zone, PM Prachanda laid emphasis on the need of creating environment for investment taking private sector into the confidence.

He mentioned, "The SEZ project will not be successful without involving private sector. The government is with private sector."

Sharing that ailing industries would be brought back into operation adopting private-public partnership, the Prime Minister expressed the belief that SEZ would play significant role to the production and promotion of export, thereby propelling the country to the path of prosperity.(RSS)

As the fiscal year 2080 BS is gradually coming to its end, Nepal government should speed up such policies in support of private sectors.

Riya Sapkota
Sindhupalchowk

TAILPIECE

A man went to his lawyer and told him, "My neighbour owes me $500 and he doesn't want to pay up. What should I do?"

"Do you have any proof?" asked the lawyer.

"Nope," replied the man.

"Okay, then write him a letter asking him for the $1000 he owed you," said the lawyer.

"But it's only $500," replied the man.

"Precisely. That's what he will reply and we will have the proof we need to nail him."

Former Pakistani Premier Khan gets 14-year prison sentence

AP
Islamabad, Jan. 31

Former Pakistani Prime Minister Imran Khan and his wife were sentenced on Wednesday to 14 years in prison each for corruption, his lawyer and prison officials said, a day after another special court convicted Khan of leaking state secrets and gave him a 10-year prison sentence.

The latest conviction and sentencing were Khan's third since 2022, when he was ousted from power, and came ahead of Pakistan's Feb. 8 parliamentary elections. The sentences will be served concurrently.

Khan and his wife were accused in the most recent graft case of retaining and selling state gifts when he was in power. In Pakistan, government leaders are allowed to buy such gifts, but they aren't usually then sold. If they are, individuals must declare the earnings as income. The prosecution said Khan did not correctly disclose his income after selling the gifts he had received from foreign dignitaries and heads of state.

The couple was also fined 787 million rupees ($2.8 million) each, and the court disqualified Khan for 10 years from holding any public office.

His lawyer, Babar Awan, said the former premier was convicted and sentenced in such a hurry that the judge did not wait for the arrival of his legal team.

He said Khan's basic human and fundamental rights had been violated, and that the latest legal setbacks would be challenged in higher courts.

"It seems the judge was in a hurry to announce the verdict," he said.

Zulfiqar Bukhari, the chief spokesperson for Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party, or PTI, also confirmed the conviction and sentencing.



File Photo: AP

Pakistan's former Prime Minister Imran Khan, right, and Bushra Bibi,his wife. A Pakistani court on Wednesday, Wednesday, Jan. 31, 2024 sentenced former Prime Minister Khan and his wife Bibi to 14 years in prison for corruption, prison officials said, a day after another special court convicted Khan for leaking state secrets and gave him a 10-year prison sentence.

In a statement, Bukhari said Khan's conviction and sentencing was "another sad day in our judicial system history which is being dismantled."

Khan and his wife, Bushra Bibi, were indicted three weeks ago on graft charges for retaining state gifts including jewellery and watches from Saudi Arabia's government, authorities said. They pleaded not guilty.

Bibi was absent when the judge announced the verdict but later went to the court to avoid being arrested. She will be handed over to prison officials to serve her sentence.

Khan briefly attended Wednesday's hearing but left the courtroom when the judge was about to read the verdict. He said he could not remain there without his lawyer and asked the judge to wait. His request was denied.

Awan, his lawyer, told The Associated Press that the former premier was being side-lined ahead of the vote next week, but noted that his party remains popular. Analysts say Khan enjoys a strong grassroots following.

Awan also said Khan's trial was conducted against international and domestic laws.

Gohar Khan, the head of the PTI, said many people assumed Khan's political career was over after this latest conviction. "No, this is not the case. He is not gone and I appeal to our supporters to vote for the candidates of PTI to ensure that we win the election, and this is the best way to avenge (him)."

Khan was ousted from power in a no-confidence vote in Parliament in April 2022. He is serving time on a corruption conviction and has multiple other legal cases hanging over him.

He remains popular despite his prison sentences and being out of the public eye since last August.

Pakistan has a history of arresting former prime ministers or side-lining them ahead of elections if they are deemed to pose a challenge to the security establishment. More than two-thirds of its civilian rulers have been arrested, convicted or disqualified since the country gained independence from Britain in 1947.

In 2018, three-time premier and Khan's rival Nawaz Sharif was hobbled by legal cases and prison sentences. Khan's party won the polls and formed a coalition government.

This time around, Sharif has a clear path to a fourth term in office after the Supreme Court acquitted him on all charges and scrapped a lifetime ban on politicians with criminal convictions from contesting elections.

Muhammad Ali, an Islamabad-based political analyst, said no former Pakistani premier has been convicted and sentenced in three cases within six months. But Ali said Khan was partly to blame because his legal team kept skipping court hearings as part of a strategy to delay the trial.

150 PEOPLE ARE KILLED IN GAZA IN 24 HOURS

AP
Gaza, Jan. 31

Gaza's Health Ministry says 150 people have been killed in the territory in the last 24 hours and another 313 were wounded as Israeli forces continue to battle militants, even in the northern part of the territory.

The north, where entire neighborhoods have been flattened, was the initial target of Israel's ground offensive in late October.

Israel's military said Wednesday that its forces killed more than 15 Hamas militants in northern Gaza over the past day and targeted militant infrastructure in a school.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has rejected two key demands made by Hamas in indirect cease-fire talks, saying that Israel will not withdraw from the Gaza Strip or release thousands of jailed militants.

The latest deaths bring the Palestinian death toll from Israel's offensive to 26,900, according to the Hamas-controlled Health Ministry. It does not distinguish between civilian and combatant deaths but says most of those killed were women and children.

Hamas' Oct. 7 attack in southern Israel that sparked the war killed 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and about 250 people were taken hostage, according to Israeli authorities.

PRISM

Chinese grandpa becomes oldest video game vlogger

Sichuan: An 88-year-old gamer from China earned a Guinness World Record as the oldest video game content creator on video platform Bilibili.

Yang Binglin, aka "Grandpa Yang," became a viral sensation in China when he started sharing clips of his gaming sessions on video sharing platform Bilibili.

The Sichuan province man has more than 280,000 followers on the website, and frequently posts vlogs about his experiences with games including Tomb Raider and Call of Duty.

Yang was awarded the Guinness World Record for being the oldest video game content creator on Bilibili, an accomplishment the platform celebrated on social media.

Yang encourages his young fans to make a schedule that ensures they do not over-indulge in gaming.

Escaped kangaroo returned to home

Alabama: Police in Alabama said a kangaroo seen hopping loose through a town was safely captured and returned to its owner.

Dee Miller captured video of the Australian marsupial hopping through Bessemer on Sunday night and posted it to social media, where it quickly spread among the local community.

"It was real fast," Miller told AL.com.

Miller said he recorded video of the creature because he thought no one would believe him without proof.

"I know people would have said, 'No, ain't no kangaroo in Bessemer,'" he said.

Detective Justin Burmeister of the Bessemer Police Department said the kangaroo escaped from an Owen Avenue home where multiple exotic animals are kept.

Burmeister said the kangaroo was recaptured by its owner Monday evening.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1327 – The teenaged Edward III is crowned King of England, but the country is ruled by his mother Queen Isabella and her lover Roger Mortimer.
1662 – The Chinese general Koxinga seizes the island of Taiwan after a nine-month siege.
1793 – French Revolutionary Wars: France declares war on the United Kingdom and the Netherlands.
1796 – The capital of Upper Canada is moved from Newark to York.
1835 – Slavery is abolished in Mauritius.
1861 – American Civil War: Texas secedes from the United States and joins the Confederacy a week later.
1864 – Second Schleswig War: Prussian forces crossed the border into Schleswig, starting the war.
1865 – President Abraham Lincoln signs the Thirteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.
1884 – The first volume (A to Ant) of the Oxford English Dictionary is published.
1900 – Great Britain, defeated by Boers in key battles, names Lord Roberts commander of British forces in South Africa.

Iran threatens to 'decisively respond' to any US strikes

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 31

Iran threatened Wednesday to "decisively respond" to any U.S. attack on the Islamic Republic following President Joe Biden's linking of Tehran to the killing of three U.S. soldiers at a military base in Jordan.

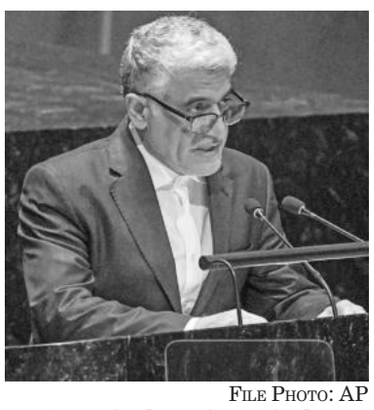
The U.S. has signalled it is preparing for retaliatory strikes in the Mideast in the wake of the Sunday drone attack that also injured at least 40 troops at Tower 22, a secretive base in north-eastern Jordan that's been crucial to the American presence in neighbouring Syria.

However, concerns remain that any additional American strikes could further inflame a region already roiled by Israel's ongoing war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip and the ongoing attacks by Yemen's Houthi rebels on shipping in the Red Sea.

A U.S. Navy destroyer in the waterway shot down an anti-ship cruise missile launched by the Houthis late Tuesday, the latest attack targeting American forces patrolling the key maritime trade route, officials said.

The Iranian warnings first came from Amir Saeid Iravani, Iran's ambassador to the United Nations in New York. He gave a briefing to Iranian journalists late Tuesday, according to the state-run IRNA news agency.

"The Islamic Republic would decisively respond to any attack on the county, its interests and nationals under any pretexts," IRNA quoted Iravani as saying. He described any possible Iranian retaliation as a "strong response," without elaborating.



File Photo: AP

Iran's United Nations Ambassador Amir Saeid Iravani addresses the U.N. General Assembly at U.N. headquarters on Feb. 23, 2023.

The Iranian mission to the U.N. did not respond to requests for comment or elaboration Wednesday on Iravani's remarks.

Iravani also denied that Iran and the U.S. had exchanged any messages over the last few days, either through intermediaries or directly. The pan-Arab satellite channel Al Jazeera, which is based in and funded by Qatar, reported earlier that such communication had taken place. Qatar often serves as an intermediary between Washington and Tehran.

"Such messages have not been exchanged," Iravani said.

But Iran's government has taken note of the U.S. threats of retaliation for the attack on the base in Jordan.

"Sometime, our enemies raise the threat and nowadays we hear some threats in between words by American officials," Revolutionary Guard commander Gen. Hossein Salami, who answers only to Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, said at an event Wednesday. "We tell them that you have experienced us and we know each other. We do not leave any threat without an answer."

"We are not after war, but we have no fear of war," he added, according to IRNA.

On Saturday, a general in charge of Iran's air defenses described them as being at their "highest defensive readiness." That raises concerns for commercial aviation traveling through and over Iran as well. After a U.S. drone strike killed a top general in 2020, Iranian air defenses mistakenly shot down a Ukrainian passenger plane, killing all 176 people on board.

Meanwhile, attacks by the Iranian-backed Houthi rebels continue in the Red Sea, most recently targeting a U.S. warship. The missile launched Tuesday night targeted the USS Gravely, an Arleigh Burke-class guided missile destroyer, the U.S. military's Central Command said in a statement.

"There were no injuries or damage reported," the statement said.

A Houthi military spokesman, Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree, claimed the attack in a statement Wednesday morning, calling it "a victory for the oppression of the Palestinian people and a response to the American-British aggression against our country."

Saree claimed the Houthis fired "several" missiles. something not acknowledged by the U.S. Navy. Houthi claims have been exaggerated in the past, and their missiles sometimes crash on land and fail to reach their targets.

El Salvador VP Ulloa admits mistakes in war on gangs

AP
San Salvador, Jan. 31

El Salvador's government "made mistakes" in its war against the country's gangs, but has never undermined the country's democracy to consolidate power, according to the man likely to be re-elected vice president.

Félix Ulloa, temporarily on leave as El Salvador's vice president while he runs for re-election alongside Nayib Bukele, defended his government's controversial crackdown in an interview with The Associated Press on Tuesday, days before a presidential election they are expected to win easily. Such policies, he said, will continue until El Salvador's gangs are defeated.

Ulloa acknowledged that in their administration's mass detention of citizens the government imprisoned thousands of people who had not committed any crime, something he said they are correcting, but justified the harsh actions as being widely popular and completely "legal."

Since declaring a state of emergency in March 2022 following a surge in gang violence, the government has detained 76,000 people — more than 1% of the population in the small Central American nation. The declaration, which suspended some fundamental rights like access to a lawyer and being told why you're being arrested, has been renewed by congress every month since.

"There is no perfect work by humans ... Look at the big picture," Ulloa said. "Understand what this country is doing when we have defended people and the human rights of millions of Salvadorans whose rights were being violated by criminal structures."

Around 7,000 people arrested under the state of emergency have since been released from prisons where authorities have been accused of torture, as well committing systematic and mass human rights abuses.



File Photo: AP

El Salvador Vice President Félix Ulloa, who is running for re-election as the running mate of President Nayib Bukele, gives an interview at his office in San Salvador, El Salvador, Tuesday, Jan. 30, 2024.

Ulloa said that in some cases officials may have asked security forces to meet quotas of detentions — arresting a predetermined number of people — but that it was "not an order from executives, nor a government policy."

Human rights groups say more than 150 people have died in custody since the beginning of the crackdown.

Reporting by the Associated Press has documented that detainees pass through mass hearings of as many as 300 defendants at a time. They rarely have access to lawyers. The vast majority of those arrested under the emergency declaration remain in prison without having been tried.

French MPs vote to enshrine abortion rights

AFP
Paris, Jan. 31

France's National Assembly on Tuesday overwhelmingly approved a bill meant to enshrine a woman's right to an abortion in the French Constitution, the first key step in a legislative process that also requires a vote in the Senate.

The measure has been promised by President Emmanuel Macron following a rollback of abortion rights in the United States.

The bill was voted Tuesday evening by the lower house of parliament by 493 votes for and 30 against.

"Tonight, the National Assembly and the government did not miss their rendez-vous with women's history," Justice Minister Eric Dupond-Moretti said.

Macron's government wants Article 34 of France's constitution amended to include that "the law determines the conditions by which is exercised the freedom of women to have recourse to an abortion, which is guaranteed."

A constitutional amendment must pass both chambers of parliament and then be approved either in a referendum or by a three-fifths majority of a joint session of parliament. Macron's government is aiming for the second method, though the measure's level of support in the Senate is less certain than in the National Assembly.

None of France's major political parties represented in parliament is questioning the right to abortion.

Yet some members of the conservative majority in the Senate have criticized the wording of the proposal, making its passage there more uncertain. If the same version of the bill ultimately passes both houses, Macron would call a special session of all legislators in attempts to win a three-fifths vote.



File Photo: AFP

Placards reading "My body my choice" and "Abortion in the constitution" are seen during a rally outside the French Senate in Paris, February 1, 2023.

Abortion in France was decriminalized under a 1975 law, but there is nothing in the constitution that would guarantee abortion rights.

The government argued in its introduction to the bill that the right to abortion is threatened in the United States, where the Supreme Court in 2022 overturned a 50-year-old ruling that had guaranteed the right to an abortion.

"Unfortunately, this event is not isolated: in many countries, even in Europe, there are currents of opinion that seek to hinder at any cost the freedom of women to terminate their pregnancy if they wish," the introduction to the French legislation says.

In Poland, a controversial tightening of the already restrictive abortion law led to protests in the country last year The Polish constitutional court ruled in 2020 that women could no longer terminate pregnancies in cases of severe fetal deformities, including Down Syndrome.

DR. SCHULZ CALLS ON PRESIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

Global President of Friederich Ebert Stiftung (FES) in Germany Dr. Martin Schulz paid a courtesy call on President Ramchandra Paudel on Wednesday.

Issuing a press statement, Shailaja Regmi Bhattarai, the spokesperson for the Office of the President, informed that the meeting took place at the Office of the President.

On the occasion, President Paudel expressed happiness over commendable initiatives undertaken by the FES office in Kathmandu in the field of politics, good governance, economy and democracy. He said that Nepal and Germany shared a friendly relationship since the establishment of bilateral relations.

PRICE OF FUEL INCREASED

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

The Nepal Oil Corporation (NOC) has increased the price of petroleum products. The new market price of petrol, diesel and LP gas or cooking gas will come into effect from 1:00 am tomorrow.

Accordingly, the price of petrol has been increased by Rs.4, diesel-kerosene by Rs.2 and LP gas by Rs.15.

The price has been revised as per the new rate received from Indian Oil Corporation today, says the NOC.

Petrol will now cost Rs. 170 per litre and diesel-kerosene Rs. 158 per litre in Kathmandu, while LPG will cost 1,910 per cylinder.

SC DEMANDS DOCUMENTS ON MARITAL RAPE CASE

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

The Supreme Court has issued an order, seeking submission of High Court Patan's document relating to a marital rape case involving suspended district judge Bhuwan Giri.

A division bench of Acting Chief Justice Ishwor Prasad Khatiwada and Justice Sunil Kumar Pokharel issued the order seeking the court document. The High Court Patan had issued order that it was not necessary to remand then judge at Rupandehi District Court, Giri.



PHOTO COURTESY: INDIAN EMBASSY, KATHMANDU

A delegation of International Relations and Tourism Committee under the House of Representatives led by its Chair Raj Kishor Yadav calls on Speaker of the Lower House of the Indian parliament – Lok Sabha on Wednesday. The 12-member delegation is on an eight-day official visit to India.

Elon Musk cannot keep Tesla pay package worth more than $55 billion, judge rules

AP
Dover, Del., Jan. 31

Elon Musk is not entitled to a landmark compensation package awarded by Tesla's board of directors that is potentially worth more than $55 billion, a Delaware judge ruled Tuesday.

The ruling by Chancellor Kathaleen St. Jude McCormick comes more than five years after a shareholder lawsuit targeted Tesla CEO Musk and directors of the company. They were accused of breaching their duties to the maker of electric vehicles and solar panels, resulting in a waste of corporate assets and unjust enrichment for Musk.

The shareholder's lawyers argued that the compensation package should be voided because it was dictated by Musk and was the product of sham negotiations with directors who were not independent of him. They also said it was approved by shareholders who were given misleading and incomplete disclosures in a proxy statement.

Defense attorneys countered that the pay plan was fairly negotiated by a compensation committee whose members were independent, contained performance milestones so lofty that they were ridiculed by some Wall Street investors, and blessed by a shareholder vote that was not even required under Delaware law. They also argued that Musk was not a controlling shareholder because he owned less than one-third of the company at the time.

An attorney for Musk and other Tesla defendants did not immediately respond to an email seeking comment.

But Musk reacted to the ruling on X, the social media platform formerly known as Twitter that he owns, by offering business advice. "Never incorporate your company in the state of Delaware," he said. He later added, "I recommend incorporating in Nevada or Texas if you prefer shareholders to decide matters."

Musk, who as of Tuesday topped Forbes' list of the world's richest people, had earlier this month challenged Tesla's board to come up with a new compensation plan for him that would give him a 25% stake in the company. On an earnings call last week, Musk, who currently holds 13%, explained that with a 25% stake, he can't control the company, yet he would have strong influence.

In trial testimony in November 2022, Musk denied that he dictated terms of the compensation package or attended any meetings at which the plan was discussed by the board, its compensation committee, or a working group that helped develop it.

McCormick determined, however, that because Musk was a controlling shareholder with a potential conflict of interest, the pay package must be subject to a more rigorous standard.

"The process leading to the approval of Musk's compensation plan was deeply flawed," McCormick wrote in the colourfully written 200-page decision. "Musk had extensive ties with the persons tasked with negotiating on Tesla's behalf."

McCormick specifically cited Musk's long business and personal relationships with compensation committee chairman Ira Ehrenpreis and fellow committee member Antonio Gracias. She also noted that the working group working on the pay package included general counsel Todd Maron who was Musk's former divorce attorney.

TWO BHUTANESE DIE IN HELAMBU JEEP ACCIDENT

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sindhupalchowk, Jan. 31

Two Bhutanese citizens were killed and five others sustained injuries in a jeep accident in Helambu Municipality-1, Sindhupalchowk district, on Wednesday.

According to the Area Police Office, Helambu, the Bhutanese nationals were killed after the jeep with registration number Ba 2 Cha 4450 fell off the road from Doring slope on Wednesday afternoon. There were six passengers including a Nepali citizen, said police.

The deceased were identified as Tenjin Wangmo, 71, and Tagpa Geng, 33, according to Police Inspector Manoj Kumar Shrestha of the Area Police Office. In the accident, jeep driver Ram Chandra Bhandari of Helambu-2, Bhutanese citizens Garcha, Hishi, Fuksidorje and Thukchhring were injured.

According to chairman of Helambu Rural Municipality Nima Gyalzen Sherpa, all the injured were airlifted to Kathmandu for treatment at the Trauma Centre of Bir Hospital.

EX-MINISTER NEMBANG AIRLIFTED FOR TREATMENT

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Jan. 31

CPN-UML leader and former minister Basanta Kumar Nembang was airlifted to Kathmandu for treatment on Wednesday.

Nembang, also a member of the House of Representatives, arrived in Taplejung on Wednesday morning to attend the party committee secretary meeting. He was initially admitted to the Taplejung Hospital on Wednesday morning when he encountered sudden health problems.

After necessary treatment, including a CT scan, at the district hospital, he was airlifted to Kathmandu for additional medical care. He was taken to Kathmandu after the hospital referred a CT scan and other tests for further treatment.

Nembang, who was elected to the House of Representatives from Panchthar in 2022, is currently serving as the in-charge of CPN-UML in Taplejung.

Previously, he served as Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport under the KP Sharma-led government.

No change in...

He informed that the bill related to transitional justice will be submitted with consensus and even if there is no consensus, it will be sent in the process.

Minister Gurung, who is also the Vice-Chairman of the Nepali Congress, clarified that the General Committee meeting of the Congress has been fixed for February 19 and will not be rescheduled.

He said that the government has decided to proceed with the winter session of the parliament starting from February 22 as a bill-making session. At least 20 to 25 bills related to the implementation of the constitution including the TRC bill, police and civil servants will be presented in the bill session.

Minister Gurung claimed that even though the 'crossvote' in the Koshi Province in the National Assembly member election has caused ripples within the alliance, it will not have much impact.

He stated that the economic condition of the country has begun to improve, highlighting the disappearance of past crises and the country's economic recovery.

He expressed his belief that the campaign of Congress in the community will help to make the relationship between the Nepali people and the Nepali Congress even closer, harmonious and strong. He said that this time, the government will not present a budget merely as a formality, as in the past. He added that there will be a thorough discussion on the budget during this session of parliament.

Nepal Army proposes to revive...

development and Gross Domestic Product of the country, send positive message to the world market, substitute imports and enhance self-reliance and check youth flight with the creation of employment within the country.

2.6 million metres cloth in 3 years

The NA's study task force has also proposed the modality of the industry's reoperation which said that it would take three years if the government makes a policy decision to hand over the factory to the Army in the current FY and works like preparation of the Detailed Project Report, selection of new machinery and procurement would be completed for the estimated production of 2.6 million metre of cloth.

Test production of cloth could begin this year, the NA said and added that it could also initiate the feasibility study for the revival of Butwal Spinning Mill.

The task force has also proposed policy and legal assistance from the Government of Nepal to revive the industry and sought support of the latter in policy and legal process of the mill's revival, clearing its remaining liability and handing it over to the NA, and using the cloth produced by the factory in government agencies.

Speaking on the occasion, Prime Minister Prachanda said that a decision would be made by the Cabinet about reviving the factory. However, he maintained that he would like to discuss the matter at the political level and conduct a study by a government team as well.

According to him, the privatisation of the country's industries had caused a decrease in production as well as employment opportunities.

Revival was possible in 2016

Earlier, in October 2016, the government had decided to run the HTF in collaboration with the Nepali Army, Nepal Police and Armed Police Force.

Then Minister for Industry lateNabindra Raj Joshi, had a plan that the three security agencies would run, along with private sector representatives on board, the textile mill in the first phase and produce uniforms for their personnel and school students.

The revival cost of the factory then was estimated at Rs. 300 million and the government study found that about 40 per cent machines and equipment were in condition.

A task force led by NPC Member Dr. Pushkar Bajracharya was also formed in 2016 to look into the possibility of the revival of the industry. The task force had concluded that there was a possibility of running the mill in a profitable way.

Gandaki gears up to draw...

discussions with experts by mid-March, informed Gandaki Provincial Policy and Planning Commission vice-chair Dr. Krishna Chandra Devkota.

He said, "We are planning to prepare the new plan within mid-April and align the budget for the upcoming year with the new five-year plan."

According to vice-chair Devkota, efforts were being made to coordinate between the 16th plan of the federal government and provincial plans. He said, "Province will present new plans based on the roadmaps of the 16th plan."

Gandaki Provincial Policy and Planning Commission member Dr. Subash Adhikari said that they would coordinate with local bodies for the effective implementation of the plans.

Similarly, province-local level partnership programmes will be introduced with a target to make the partnership plans accessible in all levels in five years.

There are 14 and 10 strategies set in the plans of the central and provincial government respectively.

The provincial government has given first priority to the agriculture in the upcoming plan followed by industry and tourism.

Govt's pro-people move has built...

Minister Sharma said that the journalism sector should stress the production and dissemination of content defending the political achievements made from people's sacrifice and discouraging the vulgar and uncivil tendencies seen at present in society.

Stating that the government was always ready for the timely development, expansion and transformation of Nepal Television, she wished that the NTV that carries with it a glorious history of four decades would emerge as a stronger and more popular broadcasting medium in the coming days.

"It would be difficult to expand the reach of television if arrangements are not made to watch television on handheld devices, taking into account the development of information technology and the changing tastes of the mass audiences," the Minister said.

She urged the NTV management to make the operation cost-effective and the service delivery quality through clean and efficient management.

Secretary at the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology Ram Krishna Subedi urged the television to play a role in reducing the negative impact that misinformation and disinformation could have on society.

Reminding that Nepal Television must practice responsible journalism by making the people well-informed, he stressed the need for television to remain active for materializing the inclusiveness adopted by the constitution.

Employees providing uninterrupted service for a long time in NTV were awarded on the occasion.

Traffic-blocking farmers now closing in on EU capital

AP
Halle, Jan. 31

Farmers blocked more traffic arteries across Belgium, France and Italy on Wednesday, as they sought to disrupt trade at major ports and other economic lifelines. They also moved closer to Brussels on the eve of a major European Union summit, in a continued push for better prices for their produce and less bureaucracy in their work.

The protests had an immediate impact on Wednesday — the European Commission, the EU's executive branch, announced plans to shield farmers from cheap exports from Ukraine during wartime and allow farmers to use some land that had been forced to lie fallow for environmental reasons.

The plans still need to be approved by the bloc's 27 member states and European Parliament, but they amounted to a sudden and symbolic concession.

"I just would like to reassure them that we do our utmost to listen to their concerns. I think we are addressing two very important (concerns) of them right now," European Commission Vice President Maroš Šefčovič said.

The rallies are part of farming protests across the EU and have shown how only a few hundred tractors can snarl traffic in capitals from Berlin to Paris, Brussels and Rome. Millions across the bloc have been facing disruptions and struggling to get to work, or seen their doctor's appointments canceled because protests blocked their way.

"It obviously has a major economic impact. Not only for our company, but for many companies in Flanders and Belgium," said Sven Pieters of the ECS transport company in Belgium's Zeebrugge North Sea port.

In France, the prosecutor in Creteil, south of Paris, said that 15 people have been placed in police custody Wednesday after they have been arrested near the entrance of the Rungis international market, where they headed with tractors.

Interior Minister Gérald Darmanin has warned farmers encircling Paris that any attempt to block the Rungis market and airports, and to enter into the capital would be considered "red lines." The Rungis market supplies Paris and the surrounding regions with fresh food.

Protesters put a big banner on the A6 highway, south of the French capital, writing: "Paris, let our farmers get through" as police armored vehicles were blocking the road. No major incidents between police and farmers have been reported so far.

A climax in Belgium is set for Thursday, when farmers plan to protest outside EU headquarters during a summit of government leaders. They will seek to get their issues on the summit agenda and win some concessions on the financial burdens they face and the increased competition from nations as far away as Chile and New Zealand.

"It is important that we listen to them," Belgian Prime Minister Alexander De Croo said. "They face gigantic challenges," from adapting to climate change to countering environmental pollution, he said.

Belgium currently holds the EU's rotating presidency, and De Croo said that he would address the issue during the summit as a late addition to an agenda centered on providing aid to Ukraine, after Russia's full-scale invasion nearly two years ago.

French President Emmanuel Macron has said he wants to hold off on a free trade deal with South American nations because of the vehement opposition of EU farmers and will discuss the issue at the summit.

Despite the widespread inconveniences, governments in the EU are treating protests, which have been mostly peaceful, with extreme caution.

Shooting of 'The World's Happiest Man' concludes



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

The shooting of 'Bhutan' in Nepali and 'The World's Happiest Man' in English, directed by Binod Paudel, has been concluded.

Hari Bansha Acharya, Dayahang Rai, Pooja Chand Lama, Richa Ghimire, Bhuwan Pyakurel, Aditi Pyakurel, and Kaushila Khanal Karmacharya from Nepal, Anuradha Majumder from India, and world-famous Hollywood actor Bruce Dern from America have joined the cast.

The director of 'Saanghuro,' Joes Pandey, and the successful personality of the Nepali theatre sector, Bimal Subedi, will also be seen in the movie.

According to a press statement issued by Awaken Production, the film shooting was completed recently after continuous efforts of five years.

Director Paudel said "This will be the first Union (SAG) movie for Nepal. Not only Bruce Dern but also famous Hollywood technicians are involved, making the technical side of this movie very strong," read the statement.

"We are confident that the story will be absorbed by the world, and we believe we will reach the world market through this movie. This is a matter of pride for Nepal and the Nepali people," he added. Produced by Mad Monkey Films, Hollywood's Vacant Light, Everest Entertainment, Thakurathi Bros, and Awaken Productions from Nepal have collaborated for the movie.

Its executive producers are Kaushila Khanal Karmacharya, L.N. Adhikari, Apar Shrestha, Ramesh Bhatt, while Rajendra Thakurathi, Amitabh Joshi, and Abeeral Thapa are the producers.

The film is planned to be released and screened worldwide by the end of 2024.

'The World's Happiest Man' participated in the 2019 Busan Asian Project Market under the title 'Akron International.'

Taylor Swift, Bad Bunny and others may vanish from TikTok

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 31

Universal Music Group, which represents artists including Taylor Swift, Drake, Adele, Bad Bunny and Billie Eilish, says that it will no longer allow its music on TikTok now that a licensing deal between the two parties has expired.

UMG said that it had not agreed to terms of a new deal with TikTok, and plans to stop licensing content from the artists it represents on the social media platform that is owned by ByteDance, as well as TikTok Music services. The licensing agreement between UMG and TikTok is expired as of Wednesday.

In a Tuesday letter addressed to artists and songwriters, UMG said that it had been pressing TikTok on three issues: "appropriate compensation for our artists and songwriters, protecting human artists from the harmful effects of AI, and online safety for TikTok's users."

UMG said that TikTok proposed paying its artists and songwriters at a rate that's a fraction of the rate that other major social platforms pay, adding that TikTok makes up only about 1% of its total revenue.

"Ultimately TikTok is trying to build a music-based business, without paying fair value for the music," UMG said.

TikTok pushed back against claims by UMG, saying that it has reached 'artist-first' agreements with every other label and publisher. "Clearly, Universal's self-serving actions are not in the best interests of artists, songwriters and fans," TikTok said.

Yet Universal Music also called new technology a potential threat to artists and said that TikTok is developing tools to enable, promote and encourage AI music creation. UMG accused the platform of "demanding a contractual right which would allow this content to massively dilute the royalty pool for human artists, in a move that is nothing short of sponsoring artist replacement by AI."

UMG also took issue with what it described as safety issues on TikTok. UMG is unsatisfied with TikTok's efforts to deal with what it says is hate speech, bigotry, bullying and harassment. It said that having troubling content removed from TikTok is a "monumentally cumbersome and inefficient process which equates to the digital equivalent of "Whack-a-Mole."

UMG said it proposed that TikTok take steps similar to what some of its other social media platform partners use, but that it was met with indifference at first, and then with intimidation.

"As our negotiations continued, TikTok attempted to bully us into accepting a deal worth less than the previous deal, far less than fair market value and not reflective of their exponential growth," UMG said. "How did it try to intimidate us? By selectively removing the music of certain of our developing artists, while keeping on the platform our audience-driving global stars."

TikTok, however said that Universal Music is putting "their own greed above the interests of their artists and songwriters."



Janakpur Literature and Int'l Theatre Festival from today



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpur, Jan. 31

A five-day 'Janakpur Literature and International Theatre Festival' is set to begin in Janakpur on Thursday.

The festival will run from Thursday to Monday and will take place at the Mahendra Narayan Nidhi Mithila Cultural Centre in Janakpurdham, it was announced during a press conference organised on Wednesday by the Maithili Development Fund.

CPN (Unified Socialist) Chairman Madhav Kumar Nepal will inaugurate the festival while Chief Minister of Madhes Province Saroj Kumar Yadav will participate in the closing ceremony, informed the organisers.

The festival aims to spread the Maithili language, literature, and culture, featuring discussions on more than 20 contemporary issues spanning art, literature, social, political, cultural, economic and other issues.

Additionally, the festival will showcase drama, music, and literature from India and Nepal, with Nepali and Indian artists performing in various languages, including Maithili, Nepali, Hindi, Assamese and Bengali.

The event is expected to bring together academics, social advocates, creative minds and political figures from both Nepal and India, informed the organiser.

Organised biennially since 2073 BS, the fourth edition of the festival is supported by the Government of Madhes Province and Janakpurdham Sub-Metropolitan City.

'SUITS' SETS NEW STREAMING RECORD

REUTERS
Los Angeles, Jan. 31

Legal drama "Suits" took the top spot as the most streamed title ever from another audience favorite "The Office" in 2023, while shows on Netflix dominated overall streaming charts, according to Nielsen data.

"Suits" racked up 57.7 billion viewing minutes in 2023, thanks to its availability on both Netflix and Comcast-owned, Peacock. "The Office" had generated 57.1 billion viewing minutes in 2020 amid pandemic-induced lockdowns, according to the report.

Some of the other widely streamed shows last year were "Bluey", "NCIS", "Grey's Anatomy" and "The Big Bang Theory".

Overall, Americans streamed 21 million years' worth of video in 2023, a 21% jump from a year earlier, as streaming firms continued to pour billions of dollars into new and licensed content to keep audiences hooked to their platforms.

Shows on Peacock, Disney+, Paramount+, and Warner Bros Discovery's Max were also among those that were widely watched.

Olivia Rodrigo on the 2024 Grammy Awards, performing rage on 'GUTS'

AP
New York, Jan. 31

The second chapter in Olivia Rodrigo 's musical story began similar to the first: with a big-hearted, full-throated piano ballad about a relationship gone awry.

But the bloodsucking "vampire" was no "drivers license," the song that kickstarted her career. Instead of descending into her loss in the song, Rodrigo stands atop of her anger, reclaiming her agency in the process. The production mirrors this progress: it is a triumphant revenge anthem, textured, theatrical, an explosive introduction to what would become her second full-length album, 2023's "GUTS."

And just like the first, it is a showstopper. This year, Rodrigo is nominated for six Grammys. The single "vampire" is up for record and song of the year, as well as best pop solo performance. "GUTS" could take home album of the year or maybe best pop vocal album, and finally, her track "ballad of a homeschooled girl" is up for best rock song.

"I love the Grammys so much!" Rodrigo told The Associated Press at the film academy's Governors Awards in Los Angeles earlier this month. "I grew up watching them. My mom and I used to, like, make predictions of who we thought was going to win every year.

And so just to be able to attend as a fan is incredible. And the fact that I'm nominated is just, you know, absolutely incredible, just unfathomable."

But in many ways, it is fathomable: Rodrigo won best new artist, best pop vocal album and best pop solo performance at the 2022 Grammy Awards for her debut album, "SOUR," and of course, for her 2021 smash "drivers license."

On "GUTS," one the Associated Press' picks for best albums of 2023, Rodrigo performs 12 tracks of big feelings balladry and riot grrrl-informed power pop-punk, the perfect soundtrack for a person entering their 20s — or for those of us who remember the frustrations of the age. It's a maturation from the somber teenage dreams of "SOUR."



HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: A major personal goal of yours could currently be stirring strife in one of your close relationships. Perhaps you need to be more careful about balancing your pursuit of your ambitions with a commitment you've already made.

Taurus: Trying to decide between duty and adventure could weigh on you today -- especially if you think that someone else is nudging you too hard in a particular direction. After the perceptive Moon shifts into your relationship.

Gemini: Joking around runs the risk of hitting a nerve at this time. Even so, that potentially feels safer than pushing directly against someone with a forceful and dogmatic attitude. Contesting this person on specific details that they're rigidly.

Cancer: Picking at a loved one has the potential to push them away now. Perhaps you're motivated by a longing for closeness. That said, criticism, however lovingly meant, isn't a good way to achieve that.

Leo: Getting bogged down in details could bury an important message you're currently trying to communicate. The real problem might be that you don't feel emotionally secure in one of your close relationships -- and no amount of nit-picking will fix that.

Virgo: A risky financial move could appeal to you at present. Whether or not your get-rich-quick scheme succeeds, however, it may not solve your underlying problem. Even if you managed to bring more money into the picture, you still might be stuck with an uncomfortably heavy workload.

Libra: Making room for your needs in a family context may now be challenging. It's probably possible to get at least part of what you want, but it won't necessarily be handed to you for free.

Scorpio: You may be reluctant to comment directly on an issue that's troubling you at the moment. Perhaps you think you can get your message across by dropping pointed hints. Unfortunately.

Sagittarius: Hanging out with friends could encourage you to spend beyond your budget right now. It's easy to get swept along when there's a fun activity on offer. You may also feel like it's a choice between being included.

Capricorn: You might currently feel like obtaining the approval of an authority figure is necessary for you to move forward. Even so, going through them probably isn't the only way for you to reach your goal.

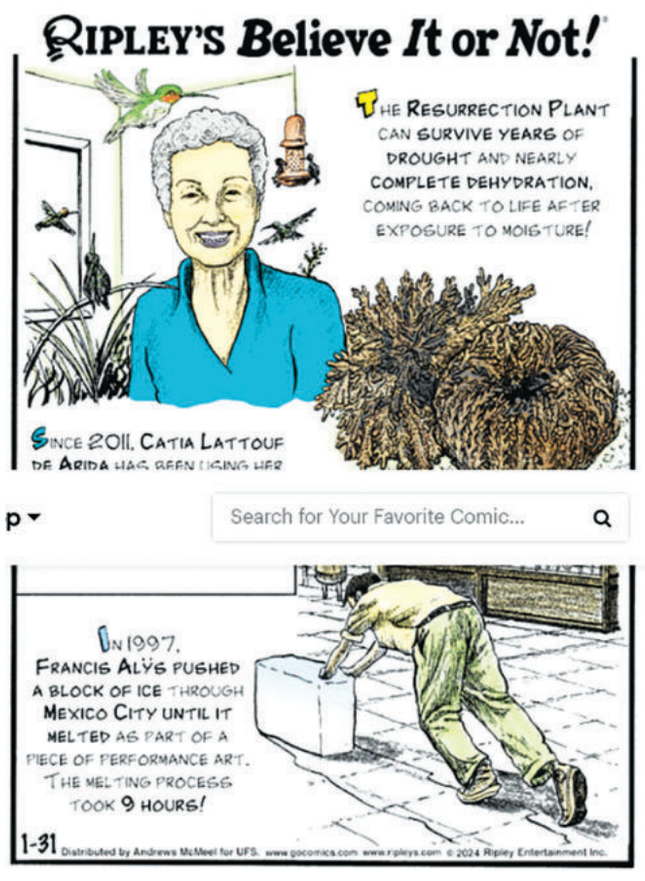
Aquarius: Thinking about an unusual experience you've had could currently test your attachment to a comforting belief. The problem could really be a question of authority. Who gets to decide.

Pisces: Finding comfortable boundaries with your current friends may be a challenge. When the emotional Moon in your intimate 8th house clashes with inquisitive Mercury in your social zone.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal U19 loses to B'desh by five wickets in Super Six

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

Nepal entered the super six stage in the ICC U19 World Cup against great difficulties. However, any chances to advance forward in the semi-finals ended after India and Pakistan went enough point forward after winning their first matches of the stage.

Playing at the Mangaung Oval, Bloemfontein, South Africa, against Bangladesh on Wednesday, Nepal's youngsters lost by five wickets while defending a low target. Winning the toss, Nepal elected to bat first as five of the seven teams who chose so lately had won in Bloemfontein.

Nepal's openers did not feel welcomed as the bowlers and fielders of Bangladesh started intimidating them from the beginning. It is uncertain if the behaviour helped Bangladesh achieve what they planned or not, but the top three batsmen of Nepal departed, all caught, within the first powerplay. Bipin Rawal, Aakash Tripathi and Arjun Kumal returned to the pavilion after adding only 2, 3 and 14 runs respectively.

Captain Dev Khanal and Bishal Bikram KC, who did not feature in any of the group matches, raised the hopes for Nepal, but it shattered after Khanal departed in the 28th over. Going well, Khanal played a poor shot directly to the hands of Mahfuzur Rahman and departed at 35 off 60.

KC, who stayed until three other wickets fell, faced 100 deliveries but felt short of two runs for his half-century while playing in the World Cup for the first time.

Experienced Gulshan Jha failed once again in the tournament as he got bowled in the 35th over as the fifth wicket contributing only three runs in 16 balls. Extras given by Bangladeshi bowlers (31 runs) was the third highest score for Nepal.



PHOTO CREDIT: CAN
Nepal's Bishal Bikram KC batting against Bangladesh during the ICC Men's U19 World Cup Cricket at Bloemfontein, South Africa, Wednesday.

While Dipak Bohora and Dipesh Kandel also added only three runs before getting out, Subash Bhandari stayed not out at 18 off 34. With one ball remaining for the 50 overs to end, Nepal lost its final wicket and got bundled out at 169.

Rohanat Doullah Borson bagged four wickets and Sheikh Paevez Jibon claimed two for Bangladesh. Iqbal Hossain Emon, Maruf Mridha and Jishan Alam also took a wicket each.

Bangladesh was more than confident to chase the target successfully. Two batsmen registered half-centuries as Bangladesh reached 170 in the 26th over losing five wickets.

Ariful Islam stayed not out at 59 off 38 with Jibon (5 off 6) to win the match for the team. Opener Jishan Alam also added 55 off 43 in the chase.

Subash Bhandari was the only wicket taker for Nepal. He bagged all five wickets in a spell of eight overs giving 44 runs.

Gulshan Jha, Aakash Chand, Dipesh Kandel and Durgesh Gupta, who replaced Tilak Bhandari, could not open their accounts for wickets.

As Nepal's youngsters continue to gain more experience in the tournament with no chance for progressing, Nepal will be facing title-defender India on February 2.

Nepal Police continues with perfect run

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

Nepal Police Club continued its perfect run at the PM Cup Men's National One Day Cricket Tournament after securing its eighth consecutive victory on Wednesday.

With a comprehensive 103-run win over Lumbini Province at Upper Mulpani Cricket Ground, Police so far has remained unbeaten in the league stage. Police Club is the first team to book a place in the final of the PM Cup. With 16 points and one match in hand, the Police sits at the top of the standings without any threat from the opponents.

The second-placed Army has 12 points and will be playing its last league stage match against Gandaki Province.

Also having 12 points each, Bagmati and Madhes are in the 3rd and 4th positions being inferior in net run rate against the Army. Having played all their nine matches, Bagmati and Madhes's title challenge is already over.

As the top two teams in the table face each other in the finals for the cup, the win over Gandaki on Thursday will earn Army 14 points and secure the berth in the final to be played on Saturday.

Table topper Police will also be facing Sudur Paschim Province on the last match day of the league stage of the PM Cup on Thursday. Sudur Paschim has eight points from eight matches.

Electing to bat first at Upper Mulpani, three national team players shined for Nepal Police as the team posted a target of 246 runs after getting bundled out in 37.3 overs. While Kushal Bhurtel fell two runs short of his half-century, Aarif Sheikh and Karan KC crossed the half-century mark.

Captaining the team in lack of Dipendra Singh Airee, Sheikh added 76 runa-ball while Karan KC exploded with six sixes and six boundaries before departing at 57 off 27. Nar Sarki bagged four wickets, Bir Magar took three, and Krishna Karki and Avishek Gautam claimed one each for Lumbini.

Lumbini, however, failed to chase the target as the team got bundled out in the 37th over for 142 runs. Dilsad Ali was Lumbini's highest scorer with 36 off 46 followed by Nar Sarki's 31 off 41.

Kushal Bhurtel was Police's highest wicket-taker in the game with three followed by Karan KC's two.



PHOTO CREDIT: CAN
Players of Karnali Province celebrating their victory over APF Club during the PM Cup Men's National One Day Cricket Tournament at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Wednesday.

Karnali stuns APF

On the other hand, Armed Police Force (APF) Club ended its hope for a place in the top four as Karnali defeated the strong departmental team by 21 runs at TU International Cricket Ground.

Having given to bat first, Karnali gave a target of 207 runs to APF and successfully defended it. APF was unable to chase the target despite Aasif Sheikh's century as only three others scored in double figures, but less than 30.

While Sheikh departed at 108 off 112 in the 42nd over, Amar Routela added 28, captain Rohit Paudel contributed 14 and opener Lokesh Bam scored 11.

Prakash Jaishi took four wickets, and Dipendra Rawat and Unish Singh bagged two each.

While there was no century from Karnali, there were two half-centuries from the bat of Himanshu Shahi (62 off 50) and Arjun Gharti (53 off 74). Likewise, Dipendra Rawat's 27 off 24 and captain Rabindra Shahi's 22 off 30 were of great help. Mousom Dhakal bagged three wickets for APF, Routela took two and Bhuvan Karki and Ramesh Kurmi claimed one each.

While the top two teams will vie for the cup, the top four teams will play in the Men's Elite Trophy scheduled for April in the domestic cricket calendar by the Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN).

CHIP TIMING AT POKHARA MARATHON

Gorkhapatra journo Regmi feted with Sports Journalism Award

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

The Ministry of Youth and Sports conferred the National 'Sports Journalism Award-2080' to Gorkhapatra journalist Govinda Regmi on Wednesday. Regmi, who works for Gorkhapatra Online, received a prize money of Rs. 50,000 along with the award. He was selected and awarded by the Ministry based on the evaluation of applications received from all over the country.

Additionally, two other Gorkhapatar journalists, Hari Prasad Koirala from Koshi Province and Rajni Kumari Yogi from Dailekh, were awarded the State 'Journalism Encouragement Award' in the province and women's category, respectively.

Moreover, the encouragement award in the province category was given to Gobindaraj Nepal (Online News) from Bagmati, Tiwari Yadav (Naya Patrika) from Madhesh, Rohitraj Parajuli (Naya Patrika) from Gandaki, Rikhiram Jisi (Samadhan Daily) from Lumbini, Nandaram Jaisi (Himalayan Times) from Karnali, and Nawaz Paneru (Barakhari Online) from Sudurpaschim. All of them received a cash prize of Rs 25,000 and a certificate of appreciation.



The Ministry has been awarding active journalists who continuously write in the field of sports every year.

The ministry also honoured nine sports personalities, including players, coaches, referees, and sports doctors. Menuka Kumari Rajbanshi (Kabaddi), Nabita Shrestha (Table Tennis), Shivasunder Gothe (Table Tennis), Erica Gurung (Karate), Shubhashree Shrestha (Table Tennis), and Palesa Govardhan (Para Taekwondo) were the players honoured in the program.

Coach Parvati Rai (Kabaddi), Judge Tejendra Singh Mahara (Table Tennis), and Physio Aviskar Pudasainai (Football) were also honoured. They were given one lakh rupees and certificates of appreciation.

Youth and Sports Minister Dig Bahadur Limbu, Secretary of the Ministry Rabilal Pant, Joint Secretary Shiv Prasad Regmi, and others gave awards to the journalists and sportsperson at the Ministry of Youth and Sports in a program organized for the same.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kaski, Jan. 31

Pokhara Marathon has prepared to use microchips in its 18th edition scheduled for February 17. As microchips will be used, organiser Nepal Ex-Sportsman Forum has requested applicants to complete their registrations by February 11.

Moreover, quotas have been set for different major categories in the marathon as the organisers have a limited number of microchips.

For instance, there is a quota for 160 runners in the 42.195-km major race followed by 50 runners in the 21-km category. Organisers are receiving 450 men and 150 women in the 10-km category for those above 16 years old. A 5-km race for school children will also be organised for 1,200 boys and 700 girls. Likewise, 50 men and 25 women can compete in the 5-km category for veterans (50+).

"With the help of the microchips, we can analyse the racers' route and timing perfectly. It will also help eliminate the chances of cheating during the marathon and motivate everyone," said Hari Prasad Parajuli, chairman of the forum.

Parajuli stressed that since there is a quota system, racers unavailable to register on time will only be able to compete at 'run for fun'. There will also be a wheelchair race, blind race and run for fun categories in the marathon.

Pokhara Marathon is receiving around 3,000 microchips from the Non-Resident Nepali Association (NRNA) and Pokhareli Manch UK among others.

The organisers will be handing over Rs. 1.8 million in total as prizes for 41 different winners under different categories.

Japan moves into quarter-finals

AFP
Doha, Jan. 31

Four-time champions Japan moved into the quarter-finals of the AFC Asian Cup Qatar 2023™ on Wednesday as goals from Ritsu Doan, Takefusa Kubo and Ayase Ueda earned the Samurai Blue a 3-1 win over Bahrain at Al Thumama Stadium.



Hajime Moriyasu's side will meet either the Islamic Republic of Iran or Syria in the last eight on Saturday after a largely accomplished performance, with the victory coming despite a wobble midway through the second half when Ueda headed the ball into his own net.

Doan put the Japanese in front in the 31st minute and Kubo doubled the lead three minutes into the second half before a 64th minute mix-up between Ueda and Zion Suzuki allowed Bahrain to halve the deficit. Ueda struck eight minutes later to restore the two-goal cushion.

S. Korea meets Australia

Son Heung-min's South Korea came back from the dead to beat Saudi Arabia 4-2 on penalties on Tuesday and will face Australia in the last eight.

Second-choice goalkeeper Jo Hyeon-woo was the hero for South Korea in Doha, saving penalties from Sami Al-Najei and Abdulrahman Ghareeb in the shootout.

Jo was only playing because of a serious knee injury to regular stopper Kim Seung-gyu in training earlier in the tournament.

After a nail-biting game ended 1-1, Hwang Hee-chan scored the decisive penalty for Jurgen Klinsmann's side, who are aiming to end a 64-year Asian Cup title drought for South Korea. Saudi coach Roberto Mancini disappeared down the tunnel before Hwang took the winning penalty.

"I think this win gives the team an enormous amount of energy," said Klinsmann, who faced fierce criticism in South Korea following draws with Jordan and Malaysia in the group phase.

In front of a crowd of 40,000 at Education City Stadium, Abdullah Radif opened the scoring for the Saudis 33 seconds after coming on as a half-time substitute.

South Korea had several chances to equalise but left it until the death to do so, sub Cho Gue-sung popping up in the 99th minute to rescue his team and force extra time.

AAha Rara Pokhara Gold Cup: Three Star into final

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 31

Three Star Club has qualified as a finalist of the 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup by defeating Jawalakhel Youth Club in the first semi-final match of the edition on Wednesday.

Ending the first half of the game goalless, Three Star won the match with a goal in the second half.

Dipesh Ghale became the super substitute for the club as he converted a pass from Dipesh Ale Magar to a goal in the 78th minute.

Three Star's side led by Bikram Lama, also a former captain of the team, will face the winner of the second semi-final match between Tribhuwan Army Club and Church Boys United being held on Thursday.

After a day's break, five-time Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup Winners Three Star will play for its sixth title on Saturday.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:51 am, Sunset at 5:44 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Generally cloudy in Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with partly cloudy in rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at a few places of Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at one or two places of hilly regions of rest of the country. Chances of light to moderate snowfall at some places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at a few places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the Provinces.

Expected Temp.: 15-17 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.1	2.9	0.0
Dipayal	22.8	4.1	0.0
Dhangadi	23.7	9.0	0.0
Birendranagar	22.0	5.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	24.0	8.2	0.0
Jumla	15.2	-5.3	0.0
Ghorahi	21.7	6.9	0.0
Pokhara	20.0	8.9	0.0
Bhairahawa	23.4	6.6	0.0
Simara	23.3	8.0	0.0
Kathmandu	18.5	4.4	0.0
Okhaldhunga	13.1	5.3	0.0
Taplejung	14.5	4.4	0.0
Dhankuta	19.5	7.0	0.0
Biratnagar	23.4	9.0	0.0
Jomsom	9.0	-5.0	0.0*
Dharan	23.0	13.0	0.0*
Lumle	14.5	5.0	0.0*
Janakpur	24.8	7.8	0.0*
Jiri	12.7	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 1, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.58	Rs. 133.18
Euro	1	Rs. 143.72	Rs. 144.37
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.14	Rs. 168.91
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.56	Rs. 154.26
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.25	Rs. 87.65
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.76	Rs. 99.21
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.98	Rs.99.43
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.97	Rs. 9.01
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.47	Rs. 18.55
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.37	Rs. 36.53
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.74	Rs. 3.75
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.10	Rs. 36.26
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.03	Rs. 28.16
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.94	Rs. 9.98
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.75	Rs. 12.81
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.28	Rs. 19.36
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.96	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.06	Rs. 433.01
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.64	Rs. 353.23

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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